

KEY JUNCTIONS WATERLOGGED

Heavy rainfall floods Ggm, disrupts traffic

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: Gurugram was flooded on Friday after heavy rain, forcing most residents to stay indoors, firms to announce work-from-home, and schools to declare a holiday and resort to online classes.

The Delhi-Gurugram Expressway was one of the worst hit. Golf Course Road was completely inundated in front of the Global Foyer Mall in DLF Sector 42. Waterlogging at several stretches led to long queues of vehicles.

Dotted with luxury apartments and commercial buildings, the Golf Course Road was especially exposed with nothing to show for its upscale.

A large section of the expressway near Cyber Hub, opposite the Gateway Tower Metro station, was submerged.

Sheetla Mata Road, which has emerged as one of Gurugram's most flood-prone locations this monsoon, was again inundated. Also exposed was the poor state of infrastructure in Rajendra Park, the Daultabad Industrial Area, and the surrounding colonies.

The Delhi-Jaipur Highway offered a contrasting picture due to a VIP visit.

The Narsinghpur area, known for waterlogging and massive traffic jams, had normal traffic. Vehicles sped along the highway, and no traffic congestion occurred anywhere.

The administration pre-



“Gurugram Tehsil received 60 mm of rainfall between 8 am and 5 pm, while Sohna recorded 82 mm...”

pared the road for restricted traffic for the chief minister's 'Van Mahotsav' programme in Manesar.

According to official data, Gurugram Tehsil received 60 mm of rainfall between 8 am and 5 pm, while Sohna recorded 82 mm. Badshahpur received 74 mm, Wazirabad received 68.5 mm, and Kadipur and Harsara each received 60 mm of rainfall. Several major intersections and service lanes, including Rajiv Chowk, IFFCO Chowk, Sohna Road, and the Delhi-Gurugram Expressway, were waterlogged.

Two labourers dead as school wall collapses

Two labourers died on the spot after a private school wall here gave way following heavy

rain on Friday, police said.

According to the police, the incident occurred when the work on the school building's extension was underway in the DLF Phase-2 area.

The two labourers were employed to remove old trees and plant new ones in their place. During heavy rainfall on Friday afternoon, they took shelter at the building when the dilapidated wall suddenly collapsed, the police said.

According to the police, the deceased were identified as Suraj and Dayanand, residents of Meerut district in Uttar Pradesh. A senior police officer said that the bodies were sent to the mortuary for post-mortem examination and a probe is underway.

Police recover 390 stolen phones, jewellery worth ₹62L, 2-wheelers

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has recovered 390 stolen and snatched mobile phones worth around Rs 1.5 crore, 66 stolen two-wheelers and apprehended 23 people, including two juveniles, during a 72-hour anti-crime drive, an official said on Friday. Police said that they also recovered illegal firearms and jewellery worth Rs 62 lakh.

"In a major breakthrough, a team has unearthed a network dealing in stolen and snatched mobile phones," a senior police officer said.

According to the police, with 66 seizures, the highest number of stolen mobile phones was recovered by Subhash Nagar police station, followed by Anti-Burglary cell, 54 and Jahangir police station, 46.

The officer said that the team has arrested two alleged burglars, both listed as bad characters of Subhash Place police station, along with three alleged receivers of sto-

'22 cases of theft and snatching were worked out'

len mobile phones. Police also arrested the mother of one of the accused after finding that she had allegedly pledged stolen gold ornaments with a gold loan company using her identity documents.

The operation led to the recovery of 54 stolen and snatched mobile phones, gold and silver jewellery worth around Rs 12 lakh, Rs 65,000 in cash, a motorcycle used in the crime and pledged gold ornaments, while 22 cases of theft and snatching were worked out, police said.

In another case, Ashok Vihar police apprehended two alleged snatchers during patrolling after they attempted to flee on a scooter. A country-made pistol, a live cartridge, a knife, a stolen mobile phone and a stolen scooter were

recovered from their possession. The duo has a combined involvement in 32 criminal cases, police said.

She said that another team arrested an alleged habitual offender and parole jumper who was found riding a stolen scooter. Police recovered five stolen two-wheelers and five stolen mobile phones at his instance.

He was allegedly involved in over 30 criminal cases and had failed to surrender after being released on parole. A team from Mukherjee Nagar police solved two vehicle theft cases by apprehending two juveniles after analysing CCTVs and recovering two stolen motorcycles from them, they said.

In another operation, Bharat Nagar police arrested an alleged bad character and recovered a country-made pistol with a live cartridge, seven stolen mobile phones and four stolen two-wheelers from his possession.

AI, nano earbuds and modified phones: Firefighter ran tech-driven government exam cheating racket

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A firefighter deployed with the Chandigarh Fire Department was allegedly kingpin of an interstate racket that enabled candidates to cheat in government recruitment examinations using concealed nano earbuds, bluetooth devices and customised mobile phones, Delhi Police said on Friday.

The cheating racket employed a highly sophisticated, technology-driven modus operandi that allowed candidates to receive answers, generated using artificial intelligence (AI) tools such as ChatGPT, in real time during government recruitment examinations, police said.

"The syndicate charged aspirants up to Rs 12 lakh and supplied specially modified electronic gadgets that allowed candidates inside examination halls to secretly receive answers transmitted from outside," police in a statement said.

Police have arrested seven persons in this connection

including the alleged mastermind, and further investigation is underway, they said.

The racket came to light after the Central Sanskrit University lodged a complaint on July 26 alleging use of unfair means during a Lower Division Clerk (LDC) recruitment examination held at a Kendriya Vidyalaya in Delhi's Janakpuri.

"During frisking at the examination centre, officials recovered a customised mobile phone from a woman candidate, while another candidate Hemant was allegedly found carrying a Bluetooth device fitted with a SIM card and concealed nano earbuds. Total 213 candidates appeared in the examination for six vacancy," the statement read.

Based on the complaint, Delhi Police registered an FIR and arrested the two candidates.

During interrogation, Hemant disclosed that the Bluetooth device and SIM card had been arranged by his brother Rinku through a contact Virender for Rs 12 lakh, so



“Police tracked Sonu to Charkhi Dabri in Hry, where he was caught facilitating cheating in another govt exam”

that answers could be relayed to him from outside the examination hall. Acting on the disclosure, a team arrested Rinku and Virender.

The arrested woman candidate told police that her friend Sanni had given her the customised mobile phone, Bluetooth device, SIM card and nano earbuds following a Rs 10-lakh deal.

Police then arrested Sanni, who named Deepak as an associate of the network.

Deepak, a Class 12-pass, allegedly arranged the electronic gadgets and coordinated the transmission of answers during examinations.

"Using technical surveillance, social media analysis and other intelligence inputs, police traced Deepak, who revealed that he was working under directions of Sonu Kumar alias Sonu Maan, the suspected kingpin," the police statement read.

Police tracked Sonu to Charkhi Dabri in Haryana, where he was allegedly caught while facilitating cheating in another government recruitment examination.

According to police, Sonu is employed as a firefighter in the Chandigarh Fire Department.

"During his arrest, the team recovered a tablet linked to a foreign account, customised mobile phones, Bluetooth devices, nano earbuds, mobile phones, SIM cards and other electronic gadgets along with

incriminating documents," the statement read.

Sharing details on the modus operandi, police said the cheating racket employed a highly sophisticated method that allowed candidates to receive answers in real time during government recruitment examinations.

According to police, the alleged kingpin, Sonu Kumar, had converted a car into a mobile control room from where he remotely assisted candidates appearing for examinations. The vehicle was equipped with a complete technical set-up, including multiple electronic devices and internet connectivity, enabling him to solve questions as they appeared on candidates computer screens.

Sonu allegedly used a car as a mobile control room, using AI to generate answers and relaying them through concealed nano earbuds. Candidates paid Rs 10-12 lakh, while police probe beneficiaries and the syndicate's wider network.

Mob barges into farmhouse, assaults caretaker, steals & occupies property; 13 caught

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: The Gurugram Police has arrested 13 persons for allegedly barging into a farmhouse here, assaulting its caretaker and his family, vandalising the property and illegally occupying it, an official said on Friday.

Three air conditioners, a refrigerator, a washing machine, a lawn mower, and various other articles allegedly stolen from the farmhouse have been recovered by police.

According to police, more than 50 people arrived in trucks, tractors and cars and forcibly entered the farmhouse located in Mahenderwara village here on Wednesday night.

Subsequently, the accused allegedly assaulted the property's caretaker and his family, threatened to kill them, attempted to outrage modesty of women present, and vandalised the caretaker's quarters.

The accused then went on a rampage, vandalising the property and destroying CCTV cameras, before decamping with household articles and other valuables.

According to a complaint by the farmhouse owner, the accused also illegally occupied the property.



Following a complaint by the farmhouse owner, an FIR was registered at Bhondsi police station and 13 persons were arrested from the farmhouse on Thursday, where they were allegedly occupying the property, police said.

During interrogation, the accused revealed they had carried out the act on the instructions of one Vipin, a Gurugram-based property dealer, a police spokesperson said.

The accused allegedly reached the farmhouse in tractors, trucks and other vehicles, assaulted the caretaker, his family and even their pet dog, vandalised the property, stole various articles and loaded them onto a tractor, the spokesperson said.

The stolen property was recovered from the residence and office of the prime accused Vipin in Dev Nagar Part-2 area, police said, adding that he is absconding and efforts are underway to trace him, besides others involved in the case.

Man nabbed for drowning pregnant daughter over 'social stigma': Police

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A man has been arrested for allegedly killing his pregnant 18-year-old unmarried daughter by drowning her in Agra's Chambal River to avoid "social stigma", Delhi Police said on Friday.

The police also arrested one of the accused's relatives for allegedly conspiring in and executing the crime.

According to the police, a PCR call was received at Tigri police station in south Delhi on July 31 alleging that a man had killed his daughter. Based on the complaint, police registered a case of abduction and murder and launched an investigation.

"During the probe, police



found that the teenager had allegedly become pregnant from a relationship outside marriage. Her father, allegedly, feared social disgrace because of the pregnancy," a senior police officer in a statement on Friday said.

The officer said the accused, along with his relative, hatched a conspiracy and

took the girl to the bank of the Chambal River near Basoni in Agra, where she was allegedly drowned intentionally.

He said that investigation revealed that the father was motivated by fear of social stigma arising from his daughter's alleged pregnancy outside marriage. "Both accused have been arrested and are being interrogated," the police officer said.

Despite extensive search operations with the assistance of local authorities in Agra, the girl's body has not been recovered so far, police said.

Search efforts are continuing along the riverbank and adjoining areas. Police said further investigation is underway.

4 held for ₹1.46 lakh fake US parcel scam

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have arrested four people, including a Nigerian woman, for allegedly cheating a Delhi resident of Rs 1.46 lakh by promising to send him a parcel containing US dollars and gold, officials said on Friday.

The accused were identified as Deepak Kumar, 22, Konda Sagar, 33, Azmeera Vinod Kumar, 30, and Nigerian national Simeon Miracle Chinoonso, 22.

Police said the victim was contacted through chats and phone calls by persons posing as US residents. He was told

that a parcel containing dollars and gold had been sent in his name and was persuaded to make payments for a money declaration certificate, flight tickets, customs clearance and release of the purportedly seized parcel. The victim transferred the money through multiple UPI IDs and bank accounts.

Police traced the accused to Delhi, Telangana and Visakhapatnam. Three allegedly supplied mule accounts for commissions, while Chinoonso posed as immigration and customs officials.

MP05T

Banned Chinese manjha supply network busted

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has arrested four persons and recovered 372 reels of banned 'Chinese manjha' following the bust of an alleged supply network operating across Delhi and neighbouring Uttar Pradesh, an officer said on Friday.

The arrests came following specific intelligence about illegal storage and sale of the prohibited synthetic kite string, police said. On August 6, one Kamran (20) was arrested near DDA Park in Jyoti Nagar and 45 reels of Chinese manjha was recovered from his possession. An FIR was registered in this connection.

During questioning, Kamran disclosed that he had procured the stock from Akash, 38, and Prem Kumar, 65, both residents of Ghaziabad. Subsequent raids led to the arrests of Akash and Prem, with the recovery of 46 and 43 reels of the banned kite string, respectively.

Based on further leads, police raided a location in Delhi's Ashok Nagar area and arrested Ravi and recovered 238 reels allegedly meant for retail distribution. Police said none of the accused have previous criminal records.

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SW Delhi: Body of man recovered from drain

NEW DELHI: The body of a man, who was feared to have been swept away in an open drain in southwest Delhi's Kapashera area, was recovered on Friday during a search operation, police said.

Efforts continued, however, to establish his identity and ascertain the circumstances leading to the incident, they said.

The search for the man had resumed for the second day in the morning with teams of the Delhi Fire Services, the District Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) and the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF). The operation was affected by incessant rainfall, overflowing water and poor visibility, officials said.

The body of the man, believed to be around 30 years old, was recovered from a section of the Bannoli drain later in the day. It has been sent for a postmortem examination, and police are examining missing persons records from nearby police stations to identify the deceased. Police are also scanning CCTV footage.

P11

Cyber Cell arrest two for routing fraud money through power bills

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Cyber Cell has arrested two men for allegedly helping cyber fraudsters convert illegally obtained money into cash by using it to pay the electricity bills of genuine consumers, officials said.

The accused were identified as Phool Singh, 30, a mobile phone dealer from Nangloi, and Sushil Kumar, 40, of Bakkarwala in West Delhi.

They were arrested during

an investigation into a cyber fraud case registered on May 14 after a Shakarpur resident was allegedly tricked into downloading a malicious APK application by fraudsters posing as Indraprastha Gas Limited (IGL) officials. The app allegedly enabled the withdrawal of Rs 2,24,995 from his State Bank of India credit card. Police found that Rs 1,82,478 of the stolen amount was used to pay a Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL) electricity bill. The transaction was

traced to the two accused.

Police said Phool Singh procured electricity bills from genuine consumers and passed them to Sushil Kumar, who allegedly routed them to an associate in Bihar. The associate paid the bills using proceeds of cyber fraud. Cash equivalent to the amount paid, after deducting commissions, was then handed over to the accused.

Two mobile phones were recovered. Police are probing their alleged links to similar cases in Mumbai, Karnataka.

FIRST-TIME BUYERS TO GET PREFERENCE

YEIDA plans 4,000 residential plots near Noida Int'l Airport

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: The Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA) is set to launch two residential plot schemes near Noida International Airport during Navratri, offering another opportunity for homebuyers seeking to invest in the rapidly developing region.

The schemes, proposed in

Sector 5A, will offer residential plots ranging from 40 square metres to 300 square metres. Officials said the schemes are aimed at both economically weaker sections and the general public. Plots measuring 40 square metres will be reserved for workers and applicants from economically weaker sections, while plots ranging from 162 to 300 square metres will be offered to general

YEIDA eyes Navratri launch for two plots

category applicants.

Although the exact number of plots is yet to be finalised, the YEIDA board has already approved the development of around 4,000 residential plots. The authority is expected to announce the application

schedule, pricing and other eligibility criteria shortly.

In a move aimed at widening access to housing, YEIDA has revised its allotment policy. Applicants who have previously been allotted a residential plot under any housing scheme of Noida, Greater Noida or YEIDA will be barred from applying under the new schemes. The move is intended to give first-time homebuyers a

greater opportunity to secure plots. YEIDA CEO Rakesh Kumar Singh said the schemes are being finalised and will soon be registered with the Real Estate Regulatory Authority (RERA). The authority is targeting a Navratri launch.

Earlier this financial year, YEIDA launched a scheme for 973 residential plots, which attracted more than one lakh applications.

PAVES WAY FOR WORLD-CLASS CAMPUSES, 25% QUOTA FOR LOCAL STUDENTS

Private Universities Bill gets Delhi Cabinet's green light

BILL NOW SET FOR ASSEMBLY CONSIDERATION AND PASSAGE

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a move aimed at transforming Delhi into a global higher education destination, the Delhi Cabinet on Friday approved the draft Bill for the establishment and incorporation of private universities in the national capital. The proposed legislation, which introduces a dedicated regulatory framework, mandates a 25 per cent reservation for Delhi students in every programme and allows multi-storey urban campuses to address the city's land constraints. The Bill will now be introduced in the Delhi Legislative Assembly for consideration and passage.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the legislation would usher in a new era of higher education in Delhi by creating a transparent and modern legal framework for setting up world-class private universities. The proposed law aims to expand academic opportunities, pro-

HIGHLIGHTS

- CM Rekha Gupta said the legislation would usher in a new era of higher education in Delhi by creating a transparent and modern legal framework for setting up world-class private universities
- The proposed law aims to expand academic opportunities, promote research and innovation, encourage

entrepreneurship, strengthen industry-academia collaboration and facilitate international partnerships in line with the National Education Policy 2020



mote research and innovation, encourage entrepreneurship, strengthen industry-academia collaboration and facilitate international partnerships in line with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.

Highlighting the need for the legislation, Gupta said many students had been forced to

leave Delhi in search of quality higher education because of the absence of a legal framework for private universities. She said, "This Bill marks the beginning of a new chapter in higher education in Delhi. Students in the capital will find better educational options within their own city, and the system will oper-

ate based on transparent rules."

The Bill also proposes a modern university model suited to Delhi's limited land availability by permitting high-rise, technology-enabled campuses instead of insisting on large, land-intensive institutions.

To safeguard students' interests, all private universities will be required to follow transparent and non-discriminatory admission procedures. The legislation also mandates that 25 per cent of seats in every programme be reserved for Delhi students, in accordance with the applicable reservation policy.

A key feature of the Bill is the creation of the Delhi Private Universities Regulatory Authority, which will oversee teaching standards, research, governance, admissions, examinations and institutional performance. Every proposal for a private university will first be examined by an expert committee comprising senior government officials, eminent academicians, UGC

representatives and financial experts before approval. The universities will be entirely self-financed and will not receive regular government grants.

Education Minister Ashish Sood described the move as a long-awaited correction to Delhi's higher education landscape.

He said, "For decades, Delhi witnessed a strange paradox. The Capital of India became the destination for students preparing for higher education, but not for pursuing higher education itself. While neighbouring States established world-class private universities, Delhi's students were compelled to leave their own city in search of quality institutions. Today, we have corrected that historic anomaly. This legislation is not merely about establishing private universities; it is about ensuring that Delhi's youth receive world-class educational opportunities within their own city. Our objective is clear, to make Delhi the knowledge capital of India."

Monsoon Session Day 1: CAG, B&B and AI take centre stage

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The first day of the Delhi Assembly's Monsoon Session on Friday witnessed a packed legislative agenda, with the government tabling multiple Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) reports, introducing the Bill to repeal the Bed and Breakfast (B&B) Act, presenting the Delhi School Education (Removal of Difficulties) Order, 2026, and announcing a pilot deployment of an Artificial Intelligence-based live transcription and translation system. The House also discussed governance, education and public expenditure, while ministers defended key government initiatives and the Speaker called for prompt corrective action on audit findings.



POWER SUBSIDY AUDIT FLAGS IRREGULARITIES

Among the CAG reports tabled in the House was an audit of Delhi's electricity subsidy scheme for the period 2019-20 to 2022-23, which flagged several irregularities in the implementation of the scheme during the previous AAP government. The report stated that Rs 42.26 crore in subsidy was released to dormant domestic electricity connections that recorded zero power consumption over consecutive billing cycles between 2019 and 2023.

The audit observed that the subsidy largely benefitted the entire domestic consumer base instead of only economically weaker sections. More than 30 lakh consumers using up to 200 units per month received an average subsidy of around Rs 6,000 annually per connection, while nearly 16.6 lakh consumers consuming 201-400 units received an average subsidy exceeding Rs 10,000 a year, almost 70 per cent higher. According to the report, higher-consuming households ultimately received a larger subsidy per connection.

The CAG noted that although "the Delhi government modified the scheme from October 1, 2022, requiring consumers to opt in for the subsidy, the overall financial burden remained largely unchanged because more consumers registered for the benefit than those who actually availed it." The audit also highlighted that the annual subsidy increased from Rs 2,405.59 crore in 2019-20 to Rs 3,161 crore in 2022-23. Power subsidy accounted for nearly 67-70 per cent of all subsidies disbursed by the Delhi government during the period.

The report recommended creating a transparent mechanism to ensure subsidies reach intended beneficiaries and reiterated earlier recommendations by NITI Aayog, the Delhi Finance Department and the Power Department to introduce Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT). However, the department said DBT was not feasible because of outstanding dues of power distribution companies to generating companies and Delhi Transco Limited. The audit also recommended data analysis and random field inspections to detect misuse of electricity connections.

UNUSED INDUSTRIAL LAND UNDER SCANNER

Another CAG report criticised the Delhi State Industrial and Infrastructure Development Corporation (DSIIDC) for leaving 81.42 acres of land at Baprola in southwest Delhi unused for over 17 years despite spending Rs 29.45 crore. The corporation had acquired 137.63 acres on a 99-year lease in 2006 by paying Rs 38.09 crore to establish a Gems and Jewellery Park and Fashion Design Hub. The projects were later replaced with a proposed Knowledge Based Industrial Park, which remained only on paper before being declared financially unviable. Subsequent proposals for shop-cum-office complexes, factories and later an Electronics City also failed to materialise. The report further pointed out unpaid ground rent amounting to Rs 15.79 crore from December 2007 to December 2024, with the liability likely to rise because of interest and penalties.

Addressing the House, Speaker Vijender Gupta said "the Public Accounts Committee had completed examination of the CAG reports tabled last year and expressed confidence that scrutiny of the reports presented this year would also be completed by year-end." He directed the Assembly Secretariat to send the reports to the concerned departments for early submission of Action Taken Notes. Gupta said, "the audit findings should be viewed as warnings to improve governance rather than merely records of deficiencies," urging departments to ensure that every rupee of public money is spent only for its intended purpose.

B&B REPEAL BILL INTRODUCED

Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra introduced the Delhi Bed and Breakfast Establishments (Repeal) Bill, 2026, seeking to repeal the 2007 legislation governing B&B establishments. The move follows the June fire tragedy at a Malviya Nagar B&B in which 21 people, including 11 foreign nationals, lost their lives. The facility was allegedly operating without mandatory approvals. The Bill is expected to be taken up for passage on Monday.

SCHOOL FEE REGULATION ORDER TABLED

The government also tabled the Delhi School Education (Removal of Difficulties) Order, 2026, to address

implementation issues in the Delhi School Education (Transparency in Fixation and Regulation of Fees) Act. The order fixes timelines for constituting School-Level Fee Regulation Committees (SLFRCs) for three-year blocks beginning with the 2026-27 academic session. Schools must constitute SLFRCs within 10 days of the order's publication in the Gazette and submit proposed fee structures within 14 days, while the Directorate of Education must establish District Fee Appellate Committees within 30 days. Existing SLFRCs formed under the December 24, 2025 order will remain valid. The order prohibits schools from charging fees higher than those applicable from April 1, 2025 until revised fees are approved and states that any excessive fees collected during 2025-26 will remain subject to the outcome of pending court cases. The government warned that failure to comply with the prescribed timelines would invite regulatory action.

Education Minister Ashish Sood said the order was necessary because committee formation under the Act would otherwise have occurred after school admissions for the academic year, and added that the government had assured courts that "schools would not increase fees until the committees were constituted."

The House also witnessed the launch of a pilot trial of BHASHINI's AI-powered live transcription and translation system, the first such deployment in any legislative House in the country, to evaluate the use of artificial intelligence in improving legislative functioning.

Meanwhile, Environment and Industries Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa accused the Opposition of disrupting proceedings instead of debating issues of public interest. He claimed the AAP had been "rattled" by the implementation of the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana and the government's higher education reforms, rejected allegations regarding the bicycle and health sectors as baseless, highlighted improved monsoon preparedness, and said the recently approved Delhi Private Universities Bill would significantly expand higher education opportunities and help establish Delhi as a national hub for education, research and innovation.

Delhi House takes AI for a live spin

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Legislative Assembly on Friday began a pilot trial of the BHASHINI AI-powered live transcription and translation system during House proceedings, becoming the first legislative House in the country to test the technology in a live setting.

Making the announcement in the Assembly, Speaker Vijender Gupta said the Digital India BHASHINI Division had been invited to conduct the pilot to evaluate how artificial intelligence can improve the efficiency and productivity of legislative proceedings.

BHASHINI, the National Language Translation Mission, was launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi during Digital India Week in Gandhinagar, Gujarat, in July 2022. The initiative aims to enable citizens to access digital public services and the internet in their preferred Indian language,

including through voice-based interaction. Powered by artificial intelligence, the platform seeks to strengthen multilingual governance and promote digital inclusion.

Calling the initiative a significant milestone, the Speaker said this is the first pilot deployment of BHASHINI's live transcription and translation system in any legislative House in the country. He said the move reflects the Delhi Legislative Assembly's commitment to adopting innovative technologies to make legislative functioning more efficient and accessible.

The pilot will be conducted on an evaluation basis, with the transcription output and overall system performance being closely monitored. Any shortcomings or observations identified during the trial will be addressed before the technology is refined and customised to suit the Assembly's operational requirements.

Delhi Metro to intensify security checks ahead of I-Day

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: With enhanced security arrangements in place ahead of Independence Day, security screening at all Delhi Metro stations will be intensified from August 9 to August 16, the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) said on Thursday.

According to the advisory, the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF), which is responsible for security at Metro stations, will carry out stricter and

more comprehensive security checks during this period as part of the heightened security measures ahead of the national celebrations on August 15.

The intensified screening is expected to result in longer queues at some Metro stations, particularly during peak commuting hours. In view of this, the DMRC has advised passengers to factor in additional travel time while planning their journeys.

In its advisory, the DMRC said, "In view of the enhanced

security arrangements ahead of Independence Day on 15th August 2026, the security checks for passengers will be further intensified by CISF across the Metro stations starting from 9th August 2026."

The corporation further cautioned that the additional checks could affect passenger movement at busy stations.

"This might result in long queues at some Metro stations especially during peak hours till 16th August 2026. Therefore, passengers are advised to

plan their journey accordingly and allow for some additional time for their commute during these days," it said.

Appealing for public cooperation, the DMRC added, "Passengers are requested to cooperate with the security personnel during security checks."

Every year, security is heightened across the national capital in the run-up to Independence Day, with key public transport hubs, government buildings and crowded public

places placed under enhanced surveillance. Delhi Metro, which carries millions of passengers daily, remains one of the primary focus areas for security agencies during this period.

Authorities have urged commuters to avoid carrying prohibited items, follow security protocols and cooperate with CISF personnel to ensure smooth passenger movement and public safety during the Independence Day security arrangements.

City Briefs

DUTA WARNS OF STRIKES IF AD-HOC FACULTY IN 12 DU COLLEGES NOT REGULARISED

NEW DELHI: The Delhi University Teachers' Association (DUTA) has announced an "Action Programme" seeking immediate regularisation of ad-hoc and temporary teachers working in 12 DU colleges fully funded by the Delhi government, warning of strikes and a mass movement if the issue is not resolved soon. The decision was taken at a meeting of the DUTA Executive Committee held on August 6, where the teachers' body finalised a strategy for intensifying its movement over the long-pending demand for absorption and regularisation of teachers who have been serving in the colleges for years.

JNUSU PROTESTS AGAINST ISKCON-LINKED EVENT; PROGRAMME 'CANCELLED'

NEW DELHI: The Jawaharlal Nehru University Students' Union on Friday held a protest outside the central library against an event that was to feature an ISKCON representative, following which the programme was cancelled, according to the student body members. The programme, titled 'Empowering Youth for a Brighter Future', was scheduled at the university's central library and included a session on "Balancing EQ, IQ and SQ".

PM Narendra Modi to address IIT-Delhi convocation today

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi will on Saturday address the 57th convocation ceremony of the Indian Institute of Technology, Delhi.

Over 3000 graduating students, including 587 PhD scholars, will be conferred their degrees during the ceremony.

Recognising outstanding academic excellence, the prime minister will present the institute's most prestigious honours, including the President's Gold Medal, Director's Gold Medal, Shankar Dayal Sharma Gold Medal, and Perfect Ten Gold Medals to meritorious students, an official statement said on Friday. Emphasising India's commitment to advancing cutting-edge research and artificial intelligence, Modi will inaugurate Param Pragma, an AI-powered high-performance supercomputing facility established at the Sonapat Campus of IIT Delhi.

ORDERS STRICTER CHECKS AT CONGESTION POINTS

L-G Sandhu pushes visible policing to ease Delhi traffic

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar T.S. Sandhu chaired a comprehensive review meeting with the Commissioner of Police, Special CP (Traffic), Joint CPs (Traffic) and DCPs (Traffic) to assess traffic management and enforcement across the Capital. The meeting reviewed the implementation of directions issued during the previous review on June 29, 2026, to ease congestion, curb traffic violations and address monsoon-related bottlenecks.

Reiterating his firm stance on traffic enforcement, the L-G said visible policing is key to reducing congestion and ensuring smooth mobility. He directed officers to maintain maximum presence at major

congestion points during peak hours, strictly penalise dangerous violations such as helmetless riding and wrong-side driving, and stressed zero tolerance towards traffic indiscipline, compromise in road safety and laxity in public mobility.

The L-G was informed that proactive measures by PWD, MCD and I&FCD reduced waterlogging locations to 65 during the current monsoon season (up to August 5, 2026), compared to 194 in 2024 and 169 in 2025. Repeated waterlogging sites declined from 53 in the previous two years to 20 this year. Traffic congestion complaints also fell, with helpline calls reducing from 701 in July 2025 to 572 in July 2026, while social media complaints dropped from 1,792 to

1,653. Under Project Sangam, 553 joint meetings were held with RWAs and MWAs. Of 510 suggestions received from residents, 410 have been implemented, while 100 were referred to civic agencies. The Traffic Pathshala initiative provided road safety counselling to over 17,400 violators across 710 key intersections.

Wrong side driving prosecutions rose 113%, from 1,64,365 challans up to July 31, 2025, to 3,51,523 during the corresponding period in 2026. Between April 8 and July 31, 2026, 2,321 FIRs were registered against severe offenders. Unauthorised parking challans increased 28 per cent to 15,36,944, while joint foot patrols cleared 399 road encroachments and prosecuted 1,915 illegal parking cases.

Manoj Kumar Dwivedi takes charge as NDMC chairperson

NEW DELHI: Senior IAS officer Manoj Kumar Dwivedi on Friday took charge as the chairperson of the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC).

Dwivedi, a 1997-batch AGMUT cadre officer, held an interaction with senior NDMC officers and heads of departments soon after assuming charge and reviewed the council's ongoing work and key priorities.

In a statement, he stressed the need for better coordination among departments, efficient delivery of civic services and a citizen-centric approach to improve amenities in the NDMC area, according to an official statement.

Prior to his new assignment, Dwivedi served as Additional Secretary (Establishment) in the Department of Personnel and Training. He

had earlier served as Additional Secretary in the Department of Commerce.

A B'Tech in Chemical Engineering from IIT Delhi, Dwivedi succeeded Keshav Chandra, who has been appointed Secretary, Ministry of Coal.

Dwivedi held several senior administrative positions during his nearly three-decade career, including Principal Secretary of the General Administration Department in Jammu and Kashmir and deputy commissioner in Leh, Rajouri and Jammu. He also served as Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Commerce and Industry and was involved in administrative coordination during the governance transition in Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh.

MP05T

COMPANY OUTLINES MEASURES TO CURB DEEPPAKES, CSAM

Centre-Meta talks turn ‘technical’

NEW DELHI: After two days of intensive questioning of Meta, the government on Friday shifted to technical discussions with the social media giant, during which the company detailed how it plans to address the Centre’s concerns over deepfakes, child sexual abuse material and unlabelled synthetically-generated content on its platforms, sources said.

Sources said that the government has asked Meta to take specific measures and report back on the outcomes.

Officials will regularly follow up with the company on its progress, sources asserted.

One of the key issues discussed was the reappearance, continued circulation and virality of AI-generated harmful content, even after it has been flagged. The government also questioned Meta on why AI-generated videos without labels continue to remain visible on its platforms despite the IT rules requiring synthetic content to be identified and labelled, sources said.

The government asked



Members of the Meta delegation arrive at Rail Bhawan to meet Union Minister for Railways Ashwini Vaishnaw, in New Delhi, Wednesday PTI

Meta to have greater human oversight in content moderation, with enhanced awareness and understanding of Indian languages, as well as local nuances.

Another meeting is expected to be held in the coming week, the sources said.

After two days of meetings that saw IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw questioning Meta’s team, led by global affairs head Joel Kaplan, on the content recommendation algorithms and

the social media giant’s compliance with local laws, day three of discussions was “technical”. It delved deep into measures proposed by the company to address the government’s concerns.

Meta explained how its systems work and outlined how it plans to address the government’s concerns over deepfakes, child sexual abuse material (CSAM) and bot accounts. The company told the government that it has solu-

HIGHLIGHTS

» Sources said that the government has asked Meta to take specific measures and report back on the outcomes

» ‘Officials will regularly follow up with the company on its progress’

» A key issues discussed was the reappearance, continued circulation and virality of AI-generated harmful content

undertake sustained measures, actions and improvements to address its various concerns, they added.

Meta’s global team had met Vaishnaw and IT Secretary S Krishnan on both days, following the government’s summons over the temporary restriction of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s Facebook post recently.

On Thursday, the Meta team was asked if it is adhering to Indian laws, grilled on algorithmic issues, and guardrails that ensure constitutional and legal requirements are being met.

The social media company had assured that it is indeed serious and “working hard” to address concerns around deepfakes, child sexual abuse material, bots and synthetic content.

On Wednesday, Meta apologised for the temporary removal of Modi’s post, as well as for failures ranging from child sexual abuse content to deepfakes and boosting certain content by being paid “a lot of money”, government sources had earlier said. PTI

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Central Ground Water Board (CGWB) has detected nitrate levels above the permissible limit in groundwater across parts of 502 districts in 26 states and Union Territories, the government informed Parliament on Friday.

Citing CGWB’s 2025 Annual Ground Water Quality Report, Minister of State for Chemicals and Fertilisers Anupriya Patel told the Lok Sabha in a written reply that 20.71 per cent of the groundwater samples analysed showed nitrate concentrations exceeding the permissible limit of 45 mg per litre. “Nitrate contamination above the permissible limit has been observed in parts of 502 districts across 26 states/UTs,” the minister said.

She was responding to a question from Congress MP Prabha Mallikarjun, who represents Davanagere in Karnataka.

On the situation in Davanagere constituency, Patel said that of 19 groundwater samples tested in the district, seven



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

(36.8 per cent) exceeded the permissible nitrate limit and two (10.53 per cent) exceeded the permissible fluoride limit, while none breached the electrical conductivity threshold.

Karnataka has 27 partially-affected districts, including Davanagere, due to nitrate contamination, the reply stated.

The government, however, admitted that the CGWB has not carried out any specific studies on pesticide residues, the environmental impact of excessive fertiliser use, health effects of agrochemical use, or soil degradation linked to agricultural chemicals.

The Karnataka government similarly said it had not conducted any exclusive study on

nitrate contamination or the environmental fallout of excessive fertiliser use in the state.

According to the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR), long-term studies have shown that imbalanced nutrient application — particularly the standalone use of nitrogen — leads to a decline in both crop yield and soil health.

“Excess nitrogen is primarily lost through nitrate leaching, resulting in groundwater nitrate contamination, with nitrate concentrations exceeding the permissible limit of 10 mg/L in some areas,” the minister said, adding that groundwater nitrate levels were found to rise in tandem with fertiliser application rates, with higher contamination recorded in areas of intensive fertiliser use.

The minister noted that excessive and imbalanced use of nitrogenous fertilisers, especially urea, causes soil acidity or alkalinity, deficiencies in secondary and micronutrients such as zinc and boron, and leaching of nitrates into shallow aquifers.

From Page 1

Heavy rain

Mahipalpur, Minto Road, ITO, Shakarpur, Chhatrapur, Red Fort, Mehram Nagar near Terminal 1, Sainik Farms and several other areas. Waterlogging at Mahipalpur T-Point disrupted traffic towards the airport, Gurugram, Chhatrapur and Vasant Vihar, while commuters also faced long delays near the Pusa Road roundabout.

In Fatehpur Beri’s Valmiki Basti, waist-deep water entered homes, damaging food stocks and household belongings. School-children unable to cross flooded lanes were carried by residents on a large plastic sheet used as a makeshift raft.

Residents said flooding had become a recurring problem. “Several families are affected whenever it rains. There is a government drain here, but further ahead farmhouse owners have blocked it,” resident Rishipal Mashe told PTI. Another resident said floodwater, nearly five feet deep in some areas, had entered houses and damaged essential supplies.

Waterlogging also affected commuters and small businesses in east Delhi. In Shakarpur and Mandawali, e-rickshaw drivers said submerged potholes and overflowing drains had caused multiple accidents.

“There are many difficulties. Potholes get submerged and sewer pits cannot be seen. At least three or four vehicles have overturned today, including e-rickshaws, scooters and motorcycles,” an e-rickshaw driver told PTI.

He said daily earnings had fallen sharply from around Rs 600 to Rs 200-300 because many passengers avoided travelling. “Water enters the battery. If an e-rickshaw overturns, especially one with a lithium battery, the loss can be Rs 60,000 to Rs 80,000,” he said.

According to civic authorities, at least 67 rain-related complaints were received across Delhi. The NDMC recorded 34 complaints, including 15 cases of waterlogging, five incidents of fallen trees and 14 power outages. The Public Works Department received 22 complaints of waterlogging.

Tree falls were reported from Keshavpuram, South, Central, West and Civil Lines zones, while waterlogging complaints in the NDMC area came from Lodhi Road, Sunehari Bagh Road, RK Ashram Marg, Minto Road Bridge, Rajiv Chowk Metro, Safdarjung Flyover, Lady Hardinge Medical College, Moti Bagh, Talkatora Garden, Race Course Road and Sarojini Nagar.

The rain also sparked political exchanges. Delhi Congress leader Mukesh Sharma alleged that drain desilting existed only on paper and accused the BJP-led Centre, the Delhi government and the MCD of failing to prevent flooding.

“There is hardly any road in Delhi... that is free from waterlogging. The government’s repeated claims that Delhi would remain free from waterlogging have proved to be completely hollow,” he said.

The Aam Aadmi Party also criticised the BJP, saying it highlighted improvements at Minto Bridge while ignoring flooding elsewhere in the city. There was no immediate response from the Rekha Gupta-led Delhi government to the opposition’s allegations.

Neighbouring Gurugram witnessed similar scenes as heavy rain flooded key roads, forcing many residents to remain indoors. The Delhi-Gurugram Expressway, Golf Course Road near Global Foyer Mall in DLF Sector 42, Sheela Mata Road, Rajiv Chowk, IFFCO Chowk, Sohna Road, Rajendra Park and Daultabad Industrial Area were among the worst affected. A stretch near Cyber Hub opposite the Gateway Tower Metro station was also submerged.

In contrast, traffic remained smooth on the Delhi-Jaipur Highway near Narsinghpur because the administration had

restricted movement ahead of the chief minister’s Van Mahotsav programme in Manesar.

Official data showed Gurugram Tehsil received 60 mm of rain between 8 am and 5 pm. Sohna recorded 82 mm, Badshahpur 74 mm, Wazirabad 68.5 mm, while Kadipur and Harsaru received 60 mm each.

The IMD said Delhi was likely to receive moderate rain at many places and heavy rainfall at isolated locations along with thunderstorms and lightning over the next few hours. Between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm, Pushp Vihar recorded the highest rainfall at 111.5 mm, followed by Chhatrapur at 104.5 mm, Ayanagar at 87.4 mm, Palam at 73.5 mm, Janakpuri at 68 mm and Safdarjung at 57.3 mm. According to IMD data, Delhi received 127 mm of rainfall during the first week of August, making it the wettest first week of the month since 2011.

Assam flood

people increased from about 1.6 lakh in 14 districts on Wednesday. Around 45,000 displaced people are staying in 133 relief camps and relief distribution centres across six districts. Floodwaters have submerged 14,382.26 hectares of cropland and damaged embankments, roads, bridges and other public infrastructure.

Rail services through the flood-hit Sivasagar section resumed in a limited manner after tracks were restored. Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said direct trains between Guwahati and Dibrugarh via Sivasagar could resume. The Northeast Frontier Railway said only diesel-powered trains would initially operate on the restored stretch as many flood-affected families were sheltering near railway tracks. MPOST

FCRA Bill

affairs on which decisions are taken by the Parliament of the country,” Jaiswal said. He added that India is not alone in regulating overseas funding. “There are several nations, including the United States, which regulate the flow of foreign funds,” he said.

The Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, has been introduced in the Lok Sabha but is yet to be taken up for discussion. The Bill proposes setting up a government-notified “Designated Authority” to manage foreign contributions and assets created through such funds when an organisation’s FCRA registration is cancelled, surrendered or lapses after not being renewed.

Under the proposed framework, the authority would provisionally manage such assets. If the organisation fails to regain registration within the prescribed period, the foreign contributions and related assets would permanently vest with the authority for use in public purposes.

The Bill also provides that if the assets include a place of worship, the Designated Authority must preserve its religious character while managing it. Another proposed change reduces the maximum punishment for violations of the Act from five years’ imprisonment to one year.

The proposed amendments have drawn criticism in the United States. Riley Moore, a Republican Congressman from West Virginia, alleged in a post on X that the legislation could “permit government takeovers of churches and religious charities”. Calling it “a clear attack against Christians”, he warned that if the Bill proceeds in its present form, it would become “a point of major concern” in bilateral relations between India and the US.

Moore also referred to Christianity’s long history in India, saying it dates back to the arrival of St Thomas the Apostle on the Malabar Coast.

US Senator James Risch, who chairs

the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, also described the proposed amendments as “deeply concerning”. He said the United States would not “hesitate to call out countries who violate the internationally recognised human rights of Christians and other religious groups around the world”.

The FCRA governs the receipt and use of foreign contributions by non-governmental organisations, charitable trusts, educational institutions, religious bodies and other associations in India. The law is intended to ensure that foreign funding does not adversely affect the country’s sovereignty, integrity, security, public interest or democratic institutions.

According to the Ministry of Home Affairs, 13,520 organisations received foreign contributions worth Rs 55,741 crore between 2019 and 2022. Government data also shows that as of July 15, 2026, India had 14,449 active FCRA registrations, while 22,498 registrations had been cancelled and another 15,212 had expired.

The proposed legislation has also prompted concerns within India. The Catholic Bishops’ Conference of India (CBCI) said the amendments could affect charitable institutions that have served poor and vulnerable communities for decades and sought safeguards to protect existing rights, legally acquired assets and ongoing charitable work.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah has met Mizoram Chief Minister Lalduhoma and representatives of the CBCI to discuss these concerns. According to the government, Shah assured them that the proposed law would not apply retrospectively.

MEA

spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said, “This is also a development that we are closely following, and we shall keep you updated.” According to Pakistan’s foreign ministry, the agreement aims to strengthen collective deterrence against aggression. It states that an armed attack on any one of the three countries will be treated as an attack on all three and provides for expanding defence cooperation across multiple areas.

Earlier, Turkey’s Haberturk television and other media outlets reported that the pact is expected to facilitate joint military exercises, training, technology transfers and intelligence sharing, according to AP.

Saudi Arabia has been expanding its defence partnerships after its key infrastructure and oil facilities came under attack during the conflict with Iran.

In September 2025, Saudi Arabia and Pakistan signed a mutual defence pact treating an attack on either country as an attack on both. At the time, Jaiswal said India was aware of the proposal and would “study the implications” of the agreement, which formalised a long-standing security arrangement between the two countries. MPOST

No frisking, poor CCTV

translated into regional languages and back translated into English to verify accuracy.

The agency said each stage should ideally be handled by different experts to ensure that no individual gains knowledge of the entire examination. However, it alleged that several experts participated in multiple stages, particularly during translation and back translation, where a single expert could access all four final master sets.

The CBI also flagged serious security lapses inside the NTAs’ confidential section, located in a separate wing on the first floor of the NSIC building in Okhla. It alleged that experts entering and leaving the facility were neither checked nor frisked.

This, the agency claimed, enabled Chemistry expert P V Kulkarni to copy 135 questions onto small slips of paper and carry them unnoticed to his hotel room over three days.

The chargesheet names Kulkarni, Zoology and Botany lecturer Manisha Gurunath Mandhare, and Physics lecturer Manisha Sanjay Havaldar as accused. The CBI alleged they exploited weaknesses in the paper finalisation process to recreate the final question paper with remarkable accuracy before sharing it with a select group of students in exchange for large sums of money.

Investigators alleged that beautician Manisha Waghmare gained access to the questions by placing students in the special coaching classes run by Kulkarni and Mandhare. Using notes prepared by these students, she allegedly reconstructed the paper and sold it through a network of middlemen. One copy eventually reached an aspirant who alerted the NTA about the suspected leak.

The CBI further alleged that after completing her translation work between March 9 and April 5, Mandhare marked relevant portions in NCERT textbooks at her hotel, using her experience to match questions with textbook content. Havaldar allegedly wrote down questions in brief after returning to her accommodation each day.

The agency also highlighted shortcomings in CCTV surveillance. It said there was no dedicated live monitoring control room for the confidential section and recordings were retained for only 20 to 25 days. Since work on the NEET UG 2026 paper concluded on April 7 and the case was registered on May 12, footage from the relevant period was no longer available. The CBI said the absence of live monitoring meant the activities of experts inside the confidential section went undetected.

The alleged leak of the May 3 NEET UG examination affected nearly 23 lakh medical aspirants, triggered a political confrontation and led to the resignation of then Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. The examination was conducted again on June 21.

Shah meets

met Shah in his Parliament House office.

As disruptions continued in the Lok Sabha, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said the Opposition could not dictate which minister should respond in the House. “The day discussion begins here and Amit Shah responds, you won’t be able to hear (digest),” Rijiju said amid sloganeering by Opposition members and desk-thumping by treasury bench MPs.

He said the government and the Chair decide which minister replies to a debate.

“You cannot dictate which minister will come to the House and who will respond. That is decided by the government and the Chair,” Rijiju said.

“Whenever Home Minister Amit Shah speaks, it will be on the relevant issue at the right time. The Opposition can only make a request, not issue directions,” he added. The Opposition has been pressing for Shah’s statement on the police action against students protesting the alleged NEET paper leak in the national capital last month. Rajya Sabha Chairman C P Radhakrishnan on Thursday had asked Rijiju to convey the Opposition’s sentiments to the home minister.

Amid the din, the Lok Sabha was adjourned till Monday. During the nearly 16-minute Zero Hour, the House passed the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026 without a debate. Parliamentary committee reports were also tabled.

Speaking to reporters later, Rijiju said Parliament continued to transact business despite repeated disruptions.

“We have passed the MSME Bill in the Lok Sabha. Business is continuing. Discussions have been fewer because the

Govt: Nitrate contamination in groundwater across 502 dists

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Central Ground Water Board (CGWB) has detected nitrate levels above the permissible limit in groundwater across parts of 502 districts in 26 states and Union Territories, the government informed Parliament on Friday.

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She was responding to a question from Congress MP Prabha Mallikarjun, who represents Davanagere in Karnataka.

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REPRESENTATIVE PIC

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The government, however, admitted that the CGWB has not carried out any specific studies on pesticide residues, the environmental impact of excessive fertiliser use, health effects of agrochemical use, or soil degradation linked to agricultural chemicals.

The Karnataka government similarly said it had not conducted any exclusive study on

Congress and other Opposition parties disrupted proceedings by raising slogans,” he said. He said there was no proposal to convene a special session while the Monsoon session was already underway.

“There is no proposal for a special session. How can we talk about a special session when the current session is still in progress?” Rijiju said.

The minister also accused the Congress of opposing delimitation and women’s reservation.

“Delimitation and women’s reservation are very important issues. The Congress opposes both. This is a betrayal of the women of the country,” he said, adding that the government remained committed to ensuring women’s rights.

Earlier in the day, Question Hour in the Lok Sabha was washed out again as Opposition members staged protests, forcing adjournment till noon.

The Monsoon session, which began on July 20, has witnessed repeated disruptions over differences between the Centre and the Opposition.

The Rajya Sabha was also adjourned for the day after repeated disruptions by Opposition members demanding Shah’s presence in the House. As soon as proceedings resumed at noon, Opposition MPs raised slogans and flagged the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya. The Chair continued with the listed business amid the din before adjourning the House till Monday.

Students to continue

The protesters also warned that they would march to the Jharkhand Assembly on August 10 if their demands were not addressed by Sunday.

Higher and Technical Education Minister Sudivya Kumar said the government was receptive to the students’ concerns. “We met the delegation of student protesters. The government is sensitive to their demands and is ready to consider them sympathetically. The outcome will be visible soon,” he said.

Minister Dipika Pandey Singh said the delegation’s demands had been conveyed to Chief Minister Hemant Soren. “The CM is concerned about students and an outcome will come soon,” she said. The protest entered its 14th day on Friday, with six protesters continuing their hunger strike. A separate group led by Devendra Mahto, who has been fasting for six days, said it had received an invitation from the government for talks and had submitted the names of an eight-member delegation.

Earlier in the day, the JPSC/JSSC Reforms Manch submitted a revised 10-member delegation after the government objected to its earlier 11-member panel, which included an advocate and two technical experts. The new panel includes student leaders Ravindra Paswan, Piyush Kumar, Rajesh Prasad, Neetu Kujur, Ankit Raj, Kartik Soren and Shalu Kumari, among others.

The protesters are also demanding an independent inquiry into the alleged recruitment irregularities, either by the CBI or by a panel of retired high court judges from outside Jharkhand.

No harassment

media and other coercive practices. The central bank had released draft norms on the issue in May and later incorporated feedback received from stakeholders before issuing the final directions.

Under the new rules, banks and other regulated entities will have to ensure that recovery agents contact borrowers only between 8 am and 7 pm. Calls or visits outside these hours will be permitted only if the borrower has specifically requested or authorised them. Recovery agents have

also been directed to avoid approaching borrowers during sensitive situations such as a bereavement, a medical emergency or a marriage function.

The RBI has prohibited threatening, intimidating or abusive behaviour during recovery. Recovery agents will not be allowed to make anonymous or threatening calls, repeatedly contact borrowers, publicly humiliate them or threaten their family members, assets or reputation. They have also been barred from using social media to shame borrowers by posting their personal information, photographs, videos or audio recordings.

The framework also introduces greater transparency in physical recovery visits. Before a recovery agency makes its first in-person visit, the borrower must be informed at least one day in advance, and the bank must disclose the details of the agency handling the case. Borrowers should normally be contacted at a place of their choice. If no preference has been provided or the borrower repeatedly fails to appear at the chosen location, recovery agents may visit the borrower’s home or workplace.

During such visits, recovery agents must carry an identity card, an authorisation letter and the relevant notice. The authorisation letter must also include the contact details of the recovery agency as well as the bank’s grievance officer.

To improve accountability, banks will be required to maintain records of recovery conversations, including call timings and phone numbers. These records must generally be preserved for at least six months. The RBI has made it clear that banks will remain responsible for the actions of outsourced recovery agencies and must monitor their conduct. It has also directed lenders to ensure that recovery agents receive proper training and that their incentive structures do not encourage aggressive recovery practices.

The framework also places stricter limits on the sharing of borrowers’ personal information. Banks have been instructed to ensure that employees and recovery agencies receive only the information necessary for carrying out loan recovery duties and to put safeguards in place to prevent misuse of personal data.

A major feature of the new norms is the formal regulation of technology-based recovery tools. The RBI has clarified that banks cannot disable smartphones, tablets or laptops to recover personal, vehicle or home loans. Such technology can be used only when the loan was specifically taken to finance that device.

Even in those cases, lenders must follow a phased approach. Device functionalities cannot be restricted immediately after an EMI is missed. Restrictions can begin only after the loan remains overdue for at least 30 days, while complete disablement can be imposed only after the account remains overdue for 60 days.

The RBI has also protected access to essential services by directing that incoming calls, SMS, emergency SOS features and functions required for work and employment must remain operational. Lenders cannot use the technology to access unrelated personal information such as contacts, photographs, videos, call logs, SMS messages or location history.

Borrowers must be informed in advance that remote restriction is possible and the condition cannot be hidden in lengthy loan agreements. Once overdue payments are cleared or the loan is regularised, the device should ordinarily be restored within one hour. If the lender fails to do so, the borrower will be entitled to compensation of Rs 250 for every hour of delay, subject to a cap linked to the outstanding loan amount.

The RBI has also accepted suggestions to ensure that only secure and reliable device-locking technologies are used. It has directed that banks and third-party service providers deploying such systems must obtain certification from the original equipment manufacturer of the device or the operating system platform before using the technology.

OVER 40 MPS, INCLUDING 3 NCPI HOLDOUTS, ATTEND MEET

Breakfast diplomacy: ‘We’re all part of NDA’, PM tells NCPI MPs, allies

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA/NEW DELHI: Amid shifting political equations, 19 NCPI MPs—barring Dipak Adhikari (Dev)—and six MPs who recently broke away from Shiv Sena (UBT) attended a breakfast meeting hosted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi at his official residence in New Delhi on Friday.

The meeting carried both symbolic and political significance, with Modi welcoming the legislators into what he described as the “NDA family”. Urging them to work together for public welfare and development, the Prime Minister told the MPs: “We are all part of the NDA family”, signalling the ruling alliance’s bid to consolidate its expanding numbers.

The attendance of the three rebel TMC Murshidabad MPs — Khalilur Rahman, Abu Taher Khan and Yusuf Pathan — drew particular attention



The MPs interact with the PM, in New Delhi, on Friday

MPOST

because they had previously skipped several NDA meetings and publicly maintained that while they were with the NCPI, they were neither part of the NDA nor would join the BJP.

Over 40 MPs from NDA constituents NCPI, Shiv Sena, Republican Party of India (Athawale), Rashtriya Lok Morcha, AIADMK and UPPL attended the meeting.

NCPI leader Jagdish Basunia described the meeting as cordial and focused on national development. “It was a great

interaction with PM Modi over breakfast today, a very cordial meeting. The PM told us we are all part of the NDA family. Let’s work together for public welfare, the way NDA works,” Basunia said.

Modi urged MPs to play a more responsible role in enacting new laws, maintain parliamentary decorum, participate actively in debates, and strengthen their engagement with constituents. He also advised MPs above the age of 40 to undergo regular medi-

The Meet

» PM Modi hosted 19 NCPI MPs (excluding Dev) and six former Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs

» Modi welcomed the legislators into the “NDA family”, urging them to work together for public welfare, development

and good governance

» The presence of Khalilur Rahman, Abu Taher Khan and Yusuf Pathan was significant as the three Murshidabad MPs had earlier skipped NDA meetings and maintained they were not part of the alliance

cal check-ups and incorporate yoga into their daily routine. After the meeting, Khalilur Rahman and Abu Taher Khan said they had raised concerns over the use of loudspeakers in mosques and sought the Prime Minister’s intervention. Abu Taher also pressed for a Railway project in his Constituency.

MP Bapi Halder demanded national fair status for the Gan-gasagar Mela, while Bankura MP Arup Roy urged the Centre to withdraw the 18% GST imposed on projects funded

through the MPLADS scheme.

NCPI MP Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar said the MPs were “overwhelmed” by the Prime Minister’s knowledge.

Meanwhile, Shiv Sena Rajya Sabha member Jyoti Waghmare said Modi emphasised on smooth functioning of Parliament. “The prime minister said due to the disruption in Parliament, the country could not listen to the talented and new MPs. He said the country’s issues should be discussed in Parliament,” he said.

BJP backs Bhagwat’s Gen Z take, Oppn sees RSS-BJP cracks

NEW DELHI: The BJP on Friday backed RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat’s remarks on Gen Z, saying Prime Minister Narendra Modi has been consistently working to help youth fulfil their dreams, while opposition leaders claimed the RSS chief’s comments exposed contradictions between the Sangh and the ruling party.

The remarks came a day after Bhagwat came out strongly in support of Gen Z, saying their grievances are genuine and he believes in their honesty, insisting protests by young people do not make them “anti-national”.

Participating in an event in Mumbai on Thursday, he noted that protest is a legitimate form of dialogue in a democracy and

should be aimed at building consensus rather than creating divisions. His comments came in the backdrop of a recent stir by a fledgling pressure group over exam paper leaks. Bhagwat said the concerns being raised over India’s education system are genuine and battling for increasing spending on the sector to 6 per cent of GDP.

Speaking to reporters BJP national general secretary Tarun Chugh said Prime Minister Narendra Modi has been consistently working to help India’s youth fulfil their dreams.

“If there is one main engine of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s agenda of a developed India, it is the youth of India. And today’s youth, whom people call Gen Z, are the ones in

whom the prime minister has the greatest faith, and he constantly works to take them forward,” he said.

BJP MP Kangana Ranaut said Gen Z is the country’s strength and welcomed Bhagwat’s remarks, saying young people are increasingly embracing India’s cultural identity.

“We are very happy that our young people are increasingly emerging as ambassadors of our culture and its identity. We have also had the opportunity to listen to Mohan Bhagwat ji, whom we hold in the highest regard, and benefit from his wisdom. It is a matter of great happiness that the country’s youth are connecting with us and embracing our cultural identity,” she said.

MPOST

‘CHHATRON KI GOONJ’ IN PRAYAGRAJ Venue row over, Cong gears up for Rahul’s event

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

PRAYAGRAJ: With the controversy over the venue resolved, the Congress on Thursday intensified preparations for Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi’s ‘Chhatron Ki Goonj’ programme in Prayagraj, claiming that nearly two lakh students have registered for the event and over one lakh are expected to attend the interaction at KP Ground on August 8.

The party said students and youth from neighbouring districts are also expected to participate in large numbers, while preparations at the venue are in full swing. Congress leaders described the programme as the beginning of a broader movement against alleged



Preps ahead of ‘Chhatron ki Goonj’ programme in Prayagraj

PTI

irregularities in competitive examinations, rising unemployment and the increasing contractualisation of government jobs. The Congress has mobilised its organisational network across Prayagraj and adjoining districts for the event. The party’s OBC Department held a meeting to coordinate the movement of students

to the venue. The meeting was attended by Congress OBC Department national chairman Dr Anil Yadav, Uttar Pradesh in-charge Rajendra Pal Gautam and state OBC Department president Manoj Yadav, who reviewed mobilisation plans.

Rahul Gandhi is scheduled to interact with students, research scholars and uni-

versity youth during the programme. The Congress said the discussion would focus on issues such as examination paper leaks, recruitment delays, unemployment and contractual and outsourcing-based employment, which it claimed have deeply affected the younger generation.

The event was thrown into uncertainty a day earlier after the Kayastha Pathshala (KP) Trust withdrew permission for the use of the KP College ground despite having earlier accepted the booking and a fee of Rs 51,000. The trust cited a 2025 Allahabad High Court order restricting the ground to educational and sports activities, along with waterlogging following recent rains, as reasons for cancelling the booking.

Andhra CM launches ‘Nethanna Sevalo’ scheme, Rs 25K to handloom families

CHIRALA: Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Friday launched the ‘Nethanna Sevalo’ welfare scheme here in Bapatla district, which will offer Rs 25,000 financial aid to eligible handloom families.

Commemorating the 12th National Handloom Day here, the chief minister launched the

scheme, benefiting 71,536 handloom families at Rs 179 crore.

“The chief minister launched the Nethanna Sevalo scheme, which offers Rs 25,000 to weavers. The CM disbursed Rs 179 crore to 71,536 handloom families,” an official release said.

Later, addressing a public meeting, Naidu observed that

weaving is not just a profession but an example of Indian culture.

He said ‘Nethanna Sevalo’ was launched today to make Handlooms Day memorable, adding that the scheme is a testament to implementing welfare schemes beyond those promised during the polls.

MPOST

AAP to take E2o fight nationwide from Aug 8

NEW DELHI: The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Friday announced that it will hold nationwide town hall meetings from August 8 to campaign against E20 fuel, with the first event scheduled in West Bengal.

AAP Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh said party chief Arvind Kejriwal has entrusted him and Delhi unit president Saurabh Bharadwaj with organising the town halls across different states.

The campaign will begin in West Bengal on August 8, followed by meetings in Gujarat and Haryana on August 9, Telangana on August 11, Maharashtra and Madhya Pradesh on August 14, Kerala on August 15, Tamil Nadu, Bihar and Odisha on August 16, and Himachal Pradesh and Chhattisgarh on August 17, Singh said.

He said the campaign would focus on the party’s concerns over the use of E20 fuel, claiming that nearly 30 crore vehicles in the country were not designed to run on the fuel blend. He said the town halls would seek to raise public awareness about the issue.

MPOST

TN backs ‘fair tax devolution’ from Centre

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu Assembly on Friday adopted a unanimous resolution seeking fair tax devolution to the state from the Centre in sync with the Constitutional principles of fiscal and cooperative federalism. Finance Minister N Marie Wilson tabled the resolution seeking appropriate tax devolution to Tamil Nadu by the Union government from the taxes it collects. The minister said fiscal federalism and cooperative federalism are the Constitution’s basic principles.

AGENCIES

Committed to socio-economic survey for social justice: K’taka CM Shivakumar

BENGALURU: Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Friday said his government was committed to implementing its socio-economic survey to ensure social justice for all sections of society and called for a caste census to provide equal opportunities.

Inaugurating the 11th National Convention of the National OBC Federation at Jnanajyothi Auditorium here, Shivakumar said his government had conducted a socio-economic survey.

The Congress was committed to the principle of “equal share and equal opportunity” and asserted that a caste census was necessary to reduce disparities among communities.



The socio-educational survey was taken up by the previous Chief Minister Siddaramaiah. The nine-member panel was headed by former Advocate General Madhusudan R Naik, who submitted his report to the state government on May 27, 2026.

The report aims to identify the backward communities, their size, problems and ways

to elevate their socio-educational status.

“We are moving forward on the principle of equal share and equal opportunity for all. Discussions on equality were held even during British rule. Therefore, a caste census was conducted around 1931. Through it, equal opportunities must be provided to all sections of society,” Shivakumar said.

He underlined that the Congress leadership is committed to conducting a caste census.

The chief minister said backward classes accounted for 52 per cent of the country’s population and claimed that Congress governments had historically worked to protect the interests of all sections.

MPOST

Digital health gets major boost with 25 crore OPD registrations, says govt

Online consultations emerge as a key pillar of India’s expanding digital health ecosystem

NEW DELHI: In a milestone towards advancing digital healthcare delivery in the country, the Scan and Register service (earlier known as Scan and Share) under the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission has crossed 25 crore OPD registrations, the Union health ministry said on Friday.

Since its launch in October 2022, the service has enabled patients to complete OPD registration digitally through a simple QR-code scan, making the process faster and more convenient, the health ministry said in a statement.

The milestone underscores rapid expansion of citizen-centric digital services under the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission (ABDM) and reflects the increasing adoption of ABHA-enabled digital health solutions across the country, the ministry said. Scan and Register enables patients to scan the unique QR code displayed at participating healthcare facilities using any ABDM-enabled Personal Health Record (PHR)

Key Points

» Of these, 24,323 are public healthcare facilities, while 6,481 are private. The rapid expansion of the service across diverse healthcare settings demonstrates the collaborative efforts of the Centre, state governments, healthcare facilities and digital

solution companies in strengthening healthcare delivery under ABDM

» On an average, nearly four lakh patients use the Scan and Register service every day for OPD registration, reflecting the growing trust of citizens in digital healthcare services, the statement said

application.

After providing consent, patients can securely share their Ayushman Bharat Health Account (ABHA) profile with the healthcare facility, enabling instant out-patient department (OPD) registration, without the need for manual registration or paper-based forms.

Since launch, Scan and Register has emerged as one of the country’s most widely adopted digital health services, enabling seamless OPD registration for millions of patients

while strengthening digital service delivery across healthcare facilities, the statement said.

The Scan and Register service is currently operational across 30,800 healthcare facilities spanning 36 states and Union territories, and 756 districts across the country, it said.

Of these, 24,323 are public healthcare facilities, while 6,481 are private. The rapid expansion of the service across diverse healthcare settings demonstrates the collaborative efforts of the Centre.

AGENCIES

COURT NOTICE
(U/c 5 Rule 20 CPC)
(SUCCESSION CASE)
IN THE COURT OF Sh.Rajeev
Additional Civil Judge (Senior Division) Hisar

1. Naveen Kumar s/o Late Satpal Kumar R/o ward No. 10, Bharat Nagar, Hisar etc.

Vs

General Public
CNR No. HRH502-001865-2026
Next Date:- **18-09-2026**

Petition for issuance of succession certificate under section 372 of the Indian Succession Act, 1925 in respect of estates left by the deceased Santosh w/o Late Satpal Kumar and all benefits after the death of Smt. Santosh and the petitioners are entitled to succeed to and receive all benefit after death.

NOTICE TO:
General Public
In above titled case, the defendant (s)/ respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s)/ respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on **18-09-2026 at 10:00 am.**

For details logon to **https://highcourthd.gov.in/?mod = district notice & district = Hisar**
Sd/- Sh. Rajeev
Additional Civil Judge (Senior Division) dated 07.08.2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Sonu Rawat S/o Laxman Rawat R/o House No. 274, II-Block, Geeta Colony, Delhi and House No. 294, Geeta Colony, Gandhi Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 28448/2020 U/S 379/411 IPC, PS Geeta Colony, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Sonu Rawat** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Sonu Rawat** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sonu Rawat** of **FIR No. 28448/2020 U/S 379/411 IPC, PS Geeta Colony, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **15.09.2026.**

By Order,
Ms. Prema Rai
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02
East District, Court No. 15
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/10840/SHD/2026(Court Matter)

NORTHERN RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. DEE/EMU/GZB for and on behalf of President of India, Invites open e-tender for the under noted work:

1	Tender Notice No.	232-Elect-EMU-WC-03-26-27
2	Name of the work	Overhauling and Repairing of Axle Drive of Tower Wagon No. 8399 Mark 3, 2011020068 PTL and 2011100070 PTL.
3	Tender cost	NIL
4	Approximate cost	Rs. 2439591.00 inclusive of GST
5	Earnest Money	Rs. 48800.00 (payment mode available on IREPS website)
6	Completion period	12 Months
7	Validity of offer	60 days
8	Date & Time from tender advertised on IREPS website	07/08/2026
9	Date & Time from tender submission start and end	17/08/2026 to 31/08/2026 15:00 Hrs.
10	Tender closing Date & Time	31/08/2026 15:00 Hrs.
11	Date & Time of tender Opening (immediately when tender submission ends)	31/08/2026 15:00 Hrs.

Note: 1. All participant Tenderer/Tenders will submit their requisite documents along with their tender offer. "No post tender correspondence for submission of additional document shall be entertained after opening of the Technical & Commercial offer. Even suo-moto post tender letters of the tenders shall be treated as null & void". **Note 2:** Duplicate documents should not be enclosed/up loaded. Tender Notice is available on website of www.ireps.gov.in No. 232-Elect-EMU-WC-03-26-27 Date: 07.08.2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 2732/26

NORTHERN RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/Traction Distribution, DRM's Office, State Entry Road, New Delhi for & on behalf of President of India, invites open e-tender for the under noted work:

1	Name of Work with its location	Part-B(II): Provision and application of composite high voltage insulated coating under girder bridges in DUK section interconnection with Strengthening of existing TRD assets in DUK section.
2	Approx. Cost of work	Rs. 50,48,687.47/-
3	Earnest Money Deposit	Rs. 1,01,000/-
4	E-Tender Bid Online Submission Period	17.08.2026 (00.00 Hrs.) to 31.08.2026 (15.00 Hrs.)
5	E-Tender Bid Submission End Date & E-Tender Open Date & Time	31.08.2026 (15.00 hrs.)
6	Fund Allocation	RRSK (PH-36)
7	Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.ireps.gov.in

E-Tender No.: 20A-TRD-NDLS-2026-27 Dated 07.08.2026 2739/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER INFORMATION

Name of work : Cleaning of fresh air & Return air filters, AC grills and cooling/condenser coils of AC coaches during maintenance works at Washing Line/Sick Line and On-Board Electrical Escorting Duties in Primary-Based Rajdhani/Duronto/Gatiman/AC Express/Tejas Trains of EOG/Rajdhani Section & ACC/NDLS Depot over Delhi Division for three years. **Tender No.:** 30-Elect-9TR-CHG-2025-26, **Approx cost of the work in Rs.):** Rs. 16,91,99,916.75/-, **Cost of tender form :** Rs. 0.00, **Address of the Office :** Sr. Divl. Elect. Engineer/Chg/ Northern Railway, New Delhi. **Earnest Money :** Rs. 9,96,000/- **Period of completion of work :** 36 Months, **Last date & time of submission of tender :** 01.09.2026 up to 15:00 hrs. **And opening of tender :** 01.09.2026 at 15:01 hrs. **Website & notice board :** www.ireps.gov.in & Sr. DEE/Chg/DLI 2727/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC/84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Harion Singh S/o Sh. Kewal Singh, R/o House No. P-98, Pillanji Village, Sarojini Nagar, New Delhi, Mobile No. 7678345405** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 141/2025 U/S 129/55 Gambling Act, PS Sarojini Nagar, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Harion Singh** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Harion Singh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Harion Singh** of **FIR No. 141/2025 U/S 129/55 Gambling Act, PS Sarojini Nagar, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **31.10.2026.**

By Order,
Ms. Vijayshree Rathore
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
13, First Floor, Main Building
Patiala House Court, New Delhi

DP/10968/SW/2026(Court Matter)

CBI CHARGESHEET

NEET case: Three NTA subject experts ‘main’ sources of paper leak

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Three National Testing Agency (NTA) subject experts were the primary sources of the NEET-UG 2026 question paper leak, with the leaked questions allegedly passing through a network of middlemen and facilitators before being sold to candidates, according to the CBI chargesheet.

The agency recently submitted its final report before the designated fast-track court dealing with “criminal cases arising from paper leaks as well as the use of other unfair means in public examinations”.

The chargesheet identified P V Kulkarni, an NTA chemistry expert, Manisha Sanjay Havaladar, who handled physics translation, and Manisha Gurunath Mandhare, who worked on botany and zoology, as key sources of the leaked material.

According to the CBI, the three experts were provided plain sheets inside the confidential section for rough work during translation and back-translation. Kulkarni, described as the alleged mastermind, used these sheets to note down all 135 chemistry questions in brief, along with their answer options, on small chits and allegedly took them out in a concealed manner.

Mandhare, the NTA’s English-to-Marathi translator for botany and back-translator for zoology, allegedly marked relevant paragraphs in NCERT textbooks after returning to her hotel. “Due to her decades of experience with the same material, she was easily able to correlate the questions with the NCERT textbook material.”

Havaladar allegedly noted down questions in brief after

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The agency recently submitted its final report before the designated fast-track court
- » The chargesheet identified P V Kulkarni, an NTA chemistry expert, Manisha Sanjay Havaladar, who handled physics translation, and Manisha Gurunath Mandhare, who worked on botany and zoology,



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

as key sources of the leaked material

- » The CBI said its allegations were corroborated by forensic evidence

returning to her accommodation in Delhi at the end of the day. A flow chart prepared by the CBI showed the alleged movement of questions from the experts to a layer of “middlemen and facilitators”. The questions were allegedly passed to Tejas Harshadkumar Shah, Dr Manoj Bahgwanrao Shirure, Shivraj Motegaonkar, Dhananjay Nivrutti Lokhande and Shivraj Raghunath Motegaonkar. Some of them were associated with coaching institutes or consultancies.

The final stage involved the “onward distribution” of the leaked questions to candidates by Shubham Madhukar Khairnar, Mangilal Biwal, Dinesh Biwal and Vikas Biwal in Rajasthan, and Yash Yadav in Haryana. The chargesheet said Khairnar approached candidates for monetary consideration, collected their educational documents and blank cheques as security, and remained in contact with those involved in further distribution.

The CBI also cited audio recordings recovered from Mangilal Biwal’s mobile phone. An audio recording dated April 26, 2016, allegedly reflected

concern that financial greed in dealing with candidates’ parents could expose the leak. Other recordings allegedly discussed the supply of the paper by Yash Yadav four days before the examination in PDF or hard-copy form, with prices negotiated between Rs 10 lakh and Rs 12 lakh. The recordings also referred to a special arrangement involving 150 questions and a diluted set of 450 questions for other buyers.

The agency described Manisha Sanjay Waghmare as “one of the prime conspirators in the leakage and dissemination of NEET UG 2026 questions for monetary consideration”. She allegedly acted as a link between candidates and subject experts, sourcing leaked material from Kulkarni and Mandhare by sending candidates to them for special classes and collecting money from students and parents. She allegedly sold the leaked questions to Dhananjay Lokhande before the examination.

The CBI said its allegations were corroborated by forensic evidence from the Government Examiner of Questioned Documents (GEQD).

Chronology of 13 arrests in NEET paper leak

CBI’s chargesheet filed before Delhi court describes sequence of arrests

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The CBI’s chargesheet in the NEET paper leak case filed before a Delhi court recently has described the “sequence of arrests” in the case in which 13 accused persons are presently in judicial custody.

According to the chargesheet, the agency began its crackdown on May 13, with the first set of arrests of Mangilal, Dinesh and Vikas Biwal in Rajasthan, whose mobile phones contained leaked PDFs received via Telegram on April 29. On the same day, the agency arrested Yash Yadav in Gurugram and Shubham Khairnar in Nashik. Khairnar, who used the alias “Ap Broker” on WhatsApp to mask his identity, was found to have coordinated the distribution of leaked chemistry questions.

Another key arrest on May 13 was Dhananjay Lokhande in



An accused being brought to Rouse Avenue Court in connection with the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak case, in New Delhi on July 8

ANI

Pune, who allegedly attempted to destroy his phone to clear evidence before being apprehended. Manisha Sanjay Waghmare was arrested in Pune the next day.

After interrogating them, the agency arrested the alleged mastermind, P V Kulkarni, on May 15 from Latur, followed by Manisha Mandhare from Pune on May 16.

Shivraj Motegaonkar, the founder of a coaching centre

in Latur, was picked up on May 17. The final arrests in this were of Manisha Sanjay Havaladar on May 22 from Latur, and Tejas Shah along with Dr Manoj Shirure from Pune and Latur respectively on May 26.

The chargesheet said that the conspiracy was unearthed through forensic imaging of mobile devices, which recovered deleted WhatsApp chats and PDF documents containing the leaked questions.

INSIGHT

- » The agency began its crackdown on May 13, with the first set of arrests of Mangilal, Dinesh and Vikas Biwal in Rajasthan
- » Their mobile phones contained leaked PDFs received via Telegram on April 29

The National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Undergraduate), or NEET-UG, is conducted by the NTA for medical aspirants. On May 12, the NTA cancelled the NEET-UG held on May 3 for admissions in medical courses amid allegations of paper leak. A re-examination was conducted on June 21.

Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan later resigned following the protests.

Andhra woman loses Rs 1.43 cr in cyber fraud

MACHILIPATNAM: A woman from Krishna district has allegedly lost over Rs 1.43 crore after cyber fraudsters posing as Delhi Police officials threatened her with arrest in a fake money laundering case, police said on Friday.

Superintendent of Police Vidya Sagar Naidu said a case has been registered on the complaint of V Alivelu Mangamma of Paraset in Machilipatnam.

The fraudsters allegedly contacted Mangamma on June 10, claiming a money laundering case had been registered against her. Posing as investigating officials, they allegedly asked her to transfer money for “forensic verification”, promising to return it after she was cleared. She transferred Rs 1.05 crore and later nearly Rs 39 lakh through RTGS. The accused subsequently demanded another Rs 95 lakh, following which she became suspicious and approached police. MPOST

Punjab to host 41 free ‘Hamare Ram’ shows

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann on Friday attended the inaugural performance of acclaimed theatrical production ‘Hamare Ram’ in Mohali, featuring actor Ashutosh Rana, as the state government launched a cultural initiative to organise 41 free shows across 12 cities during August and September.

Addressing the packed auditorium, Mann said the initiative aimed to bring the timeless teachings and ideals of Lord Sri Ram to people through theatre and promote Punjab’s cultural heritage and traditional values. “The Punjab government is organising 41 performances of the acclaimed production across 12 cities of the state during August and September to promote the rich cultural heritage and tra-

ditional values of Punjab.”

The performances will be held in Mohali, Bathinda, Jalandhar, Ferozepur, Hoshiarpur, Amritsar, Pathankot, Gurdaspur, Patiala, Ludhiana, Sangrur and Khanna.

Mann said ‘Hamare Ram’ presents the Ramayana from unique perspectives while conveying the values of truth, dharma, compassion and harmony.

He said the initiative was particularly aimed at inspiring the younger generation to remain connected with India’s spiritual, cultural and moral heritage.

“In today’s world, where love, mutual respect and social harmony are increasingly under strain, the teachings of Lord Sri Ram continue to serve as a guiding light for humanity,” he said. MPOST

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Friday said environmental conservation was not merely a government programme but a moral responsibility of every citizen, urging people to plant at least one tree and ensure its survival.

Addressing the inaugural session of the second phase of the state-level Van Mahotsav at Manesar in Gurugram, Saini administered a pledge under the ‘Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam’ campaign. He said the Haryana government had set a target of planting 1.40 crore saplings during 2026-27.

Saini said the Van Mahotsav was not merely a plantation drive but an effort to make environmental conservation a people’s movement. Refer-



Haryana CM Nayab Saini honours a school student during the ‘Van Mahotsav’ in Gurugram

MPOST

ring to the Aravalis, he said the mountain range had provided clean air, water conservation and rich biodiversity for generations, and people must consider what they would leave for future generations.

The first phase of this year’s Van Mahotsav was launched

in Karnal on July 30, while the second phase began from Manesar. The campaign will now be expanded to all 90 Assembly constituencies.

Highlighting green initiatives, Saini said 75 Namo Parks had been developed across the state and Oxy Vans were being established at district headquarters. He said the ‘Panchvati’ plantation campaign was being implemented in villages and 610 Van Mitras were helping protect saplings.

Under the Pran Vayu Devta scheme, Rs 3,000 is being provided annually for the conservation of each of 5,360 heritage trees.

The event was presided over by state Environment minister Rao Narbir Singh, while Union Environment minister Bhupendra Yadav attended the programme as the guest of honour.

AMENDMENTS MADE THROUGH DPDP ACT

Pleas on RTI changes: SC seeks Centre’s reply

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday sought the Centre’s response on a batch of pleas challenging amendments to the Right to Information (RTI) Act made through the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, with petitioners alleging that the changes have diluted transparency by removing safeguards for disclosure of personal information.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joydymalya Bagchi and V Mohana heard submissions from senior advocate Vrinda Grover and advocate Prashant Bhushan before asking Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, to file the government’s response.

The petitions challenge the



FILE PIC

amendment to Section 8(1)(j) of the RTI Act, which deals with exemptions from disclosure of personal information. The provision was amended through Section 44(3) of the DPDP Act in 2023, changing the manner in which personal data and privacy exemptions are dealt with in requests for government information.

The petitioners contend that the amendment removes key qualifiers and the “larger

public interest override”, thereby making personal information broadly exempt from disclosure. The Centre, however, has defended the change, arguing that it does not prevent legitimate transparency but seeks to harmonise the RTI framework with the fundamental right to privacy.

Grover, appearing for one of the petitioners, said the earlier provision contained safeguards that balanced an individual’s privacy with the public’s right to know.

“The challenge is actually to the amendment to Section 8(1)(j) of the RTI. Earlier, the provision had inbuilt safeguards on the nature of personal information that could be withheld from disclosure. Those safeguards have now

been removed,” she said.

Grover said deletion of the “public interest” qualifier means personal information can be exempted without any balancing exercise, potentially excluding a broad category of information protected under Articles 19 and 21 of the Constitution.

Chief Justice Surya Kant observed that “some balancing would have to be done regarding the kind of digital personal data that requires protection”. The Solicitor General informed the bench that the Centre would file its response within two-three weeks. Appearing for an intervenor, advocate Nisha Ambani said the amendments could have serious implications for investigative journalism. MPOST

Ladakh L-G reviews landslide mitigation preparedness

LEH: Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena has directed the Border Roads Organisation (BRO) and the public works department (PWD) to conduct detailed safety audits of vulnerable road stretches in Ladakh and take immediate preventive measures to mitigate landslides and rockfalls following recent incidents that damaged property and disrupted traffic.

The directions were issued during a high-level meeting chaired by the lieutenant governor on Thursday to review preparedness and mitigation measures in the wake of recent landslides, rockfalls and flash floods in the Union Territory, officials said.

Saxena appreciated the relief operations carried out by the Army and BRO during recent flash floods and landslides and lauded the prompt road-clearance efforts.

He, however, stressed the need for proactive measures at vulnerable locations to prevent recurrence of such incidents and ensure uninterrupted road connectivity.

The L-G directed the agencies concerned to undertake a comprehensive safety audit of around 15 identified high-risk locations on the Leh-Kargil National Highway and four to five vulnerable stretches on the Khardung La axis of the Leh-Nubra road.

He asked officials to assess unstable slopes and remove loose and potentially hazardous rocks before they pose a threat to commuters.

Saxena said the focus should be on engineering and technology-based mitigation to ensure safer roads, uninterrupted connectivity and greater resilience against natural hazards.

“The recent flash floods, landslides and rockfalls have once again underlined the need to strengthen our preparedness and move beyond reactive response to proactive prevention,” he said. MPOST

Diplomatic talks: ‘India, China reviewed situation along LAC’

NEW DELHI: India and China reviewed the overall situation along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) and deliberated on key issues related to boundary delimitation, border management and trans-border cooperation.

It was underlined that maintaining peace and tranquillity in the border areas is essential for the overall development of bilateral relations, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Friday, a day after the diplomatic talks between the two sides in New Delhi. “The two sides engaged in frank discussions and reviewed the situation along the LAC,” it said.

The talks were held under the framework of Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on

‘Maintaining peace in the border areas is essential for the overall development of bilateral relations’

India-China Border Affairs (WMCC). “Both sides agreed to continue to use existing diplomatic and military channels, including the WMCC, local commander-level meetings and other agreed mechanisms, to resolve outstanding issues and avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation along the LAC,” the MEA said.

As a follow-up to the outcomes of the last edition of Special Representatives talks,

the two sides held detailed exchanges on issues related to boundary delimitation, border management, mechanism-building and trans-border cooperation, it said.

The MEA said the Indian side reiterated the need for early convening of the next meeting of the expert-level mechanism on trans-border rivers and emphasised the importance of sharing technical details on upstream projects, it added.

The Indian delegation at the meeting was led by Sujit Ghosh, Joint Secretary (East Asia) in the MEA. The Chinese delegation was led by Hou Yanqi, Director General of the Boundary and Oceanic Affairs Department at China’s foreign ministry. MPOST

I4C FLAGS WHATSAPP TAKEOVER CASES

Fake notices, malicious files & CEO fraud: Inside the latest cyber scam

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) under the Union Ministry of Home Affairs has warned of a rise in WhatsApp account takeover cases targeting professionals and businesspersons through malicious files disguised as account statements and regulatory communications.

According to the I4C, similar complaints have been reported from Delhi, Gujarat, Maharashtra and Rajasthan. The agency had earlier issued an advisory on June 22, 2026, warning against regulatory impersonation being used to take over WhatsApp accounts and commit financial fraud.

In the latest modus operandi, fraudsters are sending ZIP files through WhatsApp, SMS or email with subject lines such as ‘Statement of Account.zip’, ‘RBI.zip’ and ‘MCA.zip’. The files are designed to resemble account statements or notices issued by regulatory authorities.

KEY POINTS

- » I4C has warned of a rise in WhatsApp account takeover cases targeting professionals and businesspersons through malicious files disguised as account statements and regulatory communications
- » According to the I4C, similar complaints have been reported from Delhi, Gujarat, Maharashtra and Rajasthan



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

» In the latest modus operandi, fraudsters are sending ZIP files through WhatsApp, SMS or email with subject lines such as ‘Statement of Account.zip’, ‘RBI.zip’ and ‘MCA.zip’

However, the ZIP files contain Windows executable and DLL files which, when opened on a Windows computer, install malware in the form of a Trojan. The malware enables fraudsters to gain access to the victim’s WhatsApp Web session and subsequently send similar malicious links to the victim’s contacts.

The compromised account

accounts, in a tactic known as CEO fraud.

Technical analysis by the I4C’s National Cybercrime Threat Analytics Unit has detected organised cyber-crime groups operating from different countries and targeting India using advanced persistent threats and malware techniques such as DLL sideloading.

The I4C has shared the threat intelligence with CERT-In, Microsoft Defender and Indian antivirus companies to enable countermeasures. Over the past month, more than 10,000 Indians have been protected from such attacks, while more than 58,000 people were alerted about the scam through SMS header “I4CMHA-G” in the last 30 days.

The I4C advised citizens not to open suspicious ZIP or executable files and to ensure that WhatsApp is accessed only from genuine and secure devices. Cyber fraud incidents can be reported by calling 1930 or through the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal.

Hry: Hooda slams BJP govt over law & order

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Former Haryana Chief Minister and Leader of Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda on Friday accused the BJP government of failing to maintain law and order, alleging that robbery, extortion, murder and open firing had become routine in the state.

Hooda said the recent incident in Dadri had created panic among people, claiming that the crime being carried out in front of a police station showed that criminals no longer feared the law. He also cited the Centre’s Social Progress Index, which he said had ranked Haryana as the country’s most unsafe state.

On Congress’ sports policy, Hooda said the policy implemented during his government continued to receive recognition. He said 17 medal-winning athletes were directly appointed as DSPs, while cash rewards of up to Rs 5 crore were announced for medal winners.

‘UP to frame policy for 16–35 age group’

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh government will formulate a comprehensive youth policy for people in the 16 to 35 age group, with a focus on education, employment, entrepreneurship, skill development and overall personality development.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath chaired a meeting with senior officials of the Youth Welfare Department and other departments to discuss the proposed integrated youth policy. He directed officials to establish an independent State Youth Commission comprising experts to monitor, evaluate and review youth development programmes before the policy is finalised. The proposed commission will regularly assess the implementation of youth-centric schemes and recommend measures to improve their effectiveness. The Chief Minister also directed all departments to ensure that every eligible young person receives the benefits of government programmes.

Officials said the policy will cover students, sportspersons,



FILE PIC

research scholars, startup entrepreneurs and young professionals. It will include provisions for education and skill development, entrepreneurship, employment, innovation, digital empowerment, healthcare, sports, leadership development, culture and heritage.

Yogi directed officials to align skill development programmes with emerging technologies and future employment opportunities. He called for greater focus on training in artificial intelligence, robotics, cyber security, drone technology, semiconductors and other high-growth sectors.

He also directed officials to expedite the establishment of the Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel Industrial and Employment Zone and expand the Chief Minister Abhyudaya Coaching Scheme to every university and college campus in the state.



EDITORIAL
A NEW
SECURITY AXIS

The signing of the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement by Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan marks more than another exercise in military cooperation. It signals an attempt by three influential Muslim-majority states to build a security architecture less dependent on traditional external guarantors. Signed in Mecca by Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, the agreement establishes a striking collective-defence principle: an armed attack against one of the three will be regarded as an attack against all. It also envisages closer military coordination and defence-industrial cooperation. The pact has emerged amid extraordinary regional instability, including the continuing Iran conflict and renewed insecurity across West Asia. Saudi Arabia and its partners insist that the arrangement is defensive and directed against no particular country. Yet agreements of this magnitude inevitably alter strategic calculations well beyond their signatories.

The agreement did not appear overnight. Riyadh and Islamabad signed a Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement in September 2025, formalising a security relationship that had developed over decades. Discussions about a broader arrangement involving Türkiye subsequently gathered momentum, and reports by early 2026 suggested that the three countries were exploring an institutionalised collective-security framework. As recently as July, Reuters reported that they were preparing a draft mutual-defence pact separate from the Saudi-Pakistan agreement. What has now emerged therefore represents the culmination of a deliberate strategic realignment rather than a hurried response to one crisis. It also reflects Saudi Arabia's increasingly visible desire to diversify its security partnerships. Riyadh has traditionally relied heavily on the United States, but doubts about the predictability of American protection have encouraged it to cultivate alternative relationships without necessarily abandoning Washington.

Each member brings something distinctive to this arrangement. Saudi Arabia possesses enormous financial resources, strategic geography and influence across the Arab and Islamic worlds. Türkiye fields one of NATO's largest militaries and has developed a formidable indigenous defence industry, particularly in drones, missiles, armoured systems and naval platforms. Pakistan contributes a large battle-tested military, longstanding defence links with both countries and, most consequentially, nuclear weapons. The nuclear dimension will inevitably attract attention even though the new agreement does not publicly establish a shared nuclear doctrine. When Riyadh and Islamabad signed their bilateral pact last year, analysts were already debating whether Pakistan's nuclear capability had effectively entered West Asia's strategic equation. The addition of Türkiye gives the arrangement far greater conventional military and technological weight.

The temptation to describe the grouping as an "Islamic NATO" should nevertheless be resisted. NATO is not merely an attack-one-attack-all declaration. It rests upon decades of integrated command structures, interoperability, common planning, permanent institutions, agreed procedures and substantial military infrastructure. Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan still have different foreign-policy priorities. Türkiye remains a NATO member and maintains its own complicated relationships with the United States, Russia, Israel and Iran. Saudi Arabia must balance its security concerns with its economic transformation and its position as a pivotal Arab power. Pakistan's principal conventional security challenge remains India, while its economic constraints limit its ability to sustain ambitious military commitments far from home. The durability of the Mecca pact will therefore depend less on its dramatic language than on how these competing priorities are reconciled.

The larger significance lies in what the agreement says about the changing international order. Middle powers are increasingly unwilling to entrust their security entirely to a single great power. Instead, they are building overlapping partnerships, purchasing weapons from multiple suppliers and creating smaller regional coalitions. Saudi Arabia's behaviour is particularly revealing. Its diversification of defence relationships suggests not necessarily a rupture with Washington but a hedge against uncertainty. Türkiye similarly combines NATO membership with an assertively autonomous foreign policy. Pakistan, meanwhile, gains greater strategic relevance and potentially greater economic and defence-industrial opportunities by positioning itself as a security partner in West Asia. The result is a model of alignment that is flexible rather than ideological: countries cooperate intensely where interests converge without demanding agreement on every geopolitical question.

There are risks. Collective-defence commitments can deter aggression, but they can also transmit crises. A confrontation involving one member could theoretically create obligations for the others, turning a bilateral dispute into a wider regional emergency. This danger becomes particularly serious when one participant possesses nuclear weapons and another is embedded in NATO. The pact therefore needs credible consultation mechanisms and carefully defined thresholds for collective action. Deterrence works best when adversaries understand both the capability and the limits of an alliance. Ambiguity can sometimes strengthen deterrence, but excessive ambiguity can produce dangerous miscalculation.

AT
VANTAGE



SHUTAPA PAUL

THE WRITER
IS AN AUTHOR
AND MEDIA
ENTREPRENEUR

With over five crore cases pending across Indian courts, technology can help break the judicial logjam, but it must remain firmly subordinate to human judgement

LEGAL
COMPASS



ANMOL JIT SINGH

THE WRITER
IS A LEGAL
PRACTITIONER
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COMMENTARY AND
ANALYSIS

A Global Prosecution Agency should support national courts in cross-border crimes involving scattered evidence, fugitives and victims lacking effective justice

Justice Awaited

An overwhelmed judiciary is crying for technology to reduce the load of pending cases; but even then, AI must only be used with extreme caution



From e-courts to artificial intelligence, technology offers ways to tackle India's enormous case backlog

subordinate courts, which have a sanctioned strength of 30,868 judges, grapple with 7,311 vacancies. Even the Supreme Court is two judges short of its approved strength of 34.

Getting ahead of this curve is a complex matter. Judges already move at breakneck speed while hearing cases. As per a decade-old study by DAKSH (a legal research organisation), a high court judge typically spends 5 to 6 minutes hearing a listed matter; the time spent halves to about 3.5 minutes per case in lower courts. Judges in the busiest high courts of the country spend barely 2.5 minutes per case. Anywhere between 87 and 100 cases could be listed on a normal 5.5-hour workday for a judge; on busier days, these numbers can go up. Not much exists by way of more recent data, leading one to believe that not much has changed on the ground to necessitate it.

There's no denying that just as technology has disrupted other sectors, the legal ecosystem, too, remains a veritable playing field. Tech has already been making a difference and, when used, has yielded positive results in terms of actual court time. E-courts, e-filing, virtual hearings, and Online Dispute Resolution (ODR) have improved matters. The use of artificial intelligence (AI), however, remains a sticky issue. The Supreme Court is using AI in translation (SUVAS — Supreme Court Vidhik Anuvaad Software), research (SUPACE — Supreme Court Portal for Assistance in Courts Efficiency), and scheduling and management. But its rampant use remains contentious. In July, the Supreme Court cautioned against AI hallucinations while hearing a case involving the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) and the National Company Law Appellate Tribu-

nal (NCLAT), where AI-generated fake citations had been used. While our first instinct would be to use AI to lighten the judicial load, the highest court of India has repeatedly advocated a strict and cautious approach to the deployment of AI. Through its various observations this year, the Supreme Court has consistently asked lawyers and judges to be careful in their use of AI.

In the recently released draft AI rules, the Supreme Court panel has further advocated a blanket ban on the use of AI to determine judgments, proposing that AI in court must remain "strictly subservient to human judgement and judicial authority". It has also permanently disallowed the use of AI in bail eligibility or risk scoring, behaviour profiling, including witness credibility and forecasting future conduct, and the tracking and surveillance of lawyers and judges. Human review of AI-generated information is mandatory, as is a declaration in case of AI use, along with annual legal, technical, and ethical audits of AI tools. India's tech industry body, NASSCOM, has asked the Supreme Court to define what would constitute high-risk AI use in courts.

The concerns of the highest court of justice are not unfounded. The judiciary must remain governed by human intellect, judgement, transparency, and values. And while AI demands guardrails across sectors, the sanctity of sensitive areas such as the judiciary is non-negotiable. But so are the 5.03 crore pending cases that feel trapped in a black hole of injustice. Getting out of this quagmire will happen only if aided by tech and driven by judicial will — without either, the legal pile-up can never be cleared, my lords.

Views expressed are personal

Justice Beyond Borders

As crime networks operate seamlessly across jurisdictions, a treaty-based Global Prosecution Agency could bridge gaps in investigation, prosecution and accountability



Borders may divide jurisdiction, but they should not divide accountability

is a familiar pattern: evidence exists, victims wait, warrants are issued, but custody depends on politics, timing and the willingness of individual States. A Global Prosecution Agency would not need to become a world government. It would need a treaty-based mandate, independent prosecutors, regional desks, digital evidence powers, victim protection capacity, and binding cooperation duties for member States.

The strongest argument for such an agency is that prosecution is the bridge between investigation and justice. Police can collect intelligence, but prosecutors decide charges, evidence strategy, admissibility, witness protection, asset freezing and the theory of the case. In many transnational crimes, this prosecutorial chain breaks down. Evidence stored in cloud servers may be held in one legal jurisdiction, bank trails may pass through another, and victims may be too fearful to testify in the country where the crime was planned. Mutual legal assistance remains slow, extradition depends on bilateral treaties, and dual criminality rules often protect fugitives when laws differ. A Global Prosecution Agency could maintain pre-approved protocols for evidence sharing, emergency preservation of digital records, joint case files, common witness standards, and coordinated asset recovery.

The European experience offers a working lesson. One regional judicial cooperation agency handled nearly 13,000 cross-border crime cases in 2024, with its workload rising by more than 60 per cent over five years. Its work demonstrates that when prosecutors, judges and investigators sit in a structured platform, cross-border cases move faster, joint investigation teams become more practical, and evidence does not die in diplomatic correspondence. But the European model is still regional. The world needs a wider design because modern criminal markets are not confined to one continent. Drug cartels, ransomware groups, migrant-smuggling rings, wildlife networks, terror-financing channels, illegal arms brokers and child sexual exploitation networks often connect countries with unequal institutional capacity. A global agency could create the same speed and

procedural trust at a wider scale, while respecting national courts as the primary forum for trial.

India's experience also strengthens the case. The creation of Bharatpol in January 2025 shows that national agencies themselves recognise the need for faster international police and prosecutorial communication. It connects Indian law-enforcement agencies with global cooperation channels for crimes such as narcotics trafficking, arms trafficking, human trafficking, organised cybercrime, economic fraud, child sexual abuse material and terrorism. India has also seen the practical value of Red Notices and international coordination in bringing fugitives back from different jurisdictions. Yet each successful repatriation also exposes the larger problem: such outcomes depend on sustained bilateral effort, paperwork, diplomatic goodwill and the domestic law of the requested country. A treaty-based global prosecution platform would reduce this uncertainty by making cross-border case-building routine rather than exceptional.

Cybercrime makes the urgency even sharper. The new global convention against cybercrime, adopted in December 2024 and opened for signature in October 2025, recognises the central truth that digital evidence is borderless. A fraud call may originate from one country, an account may be opened in another, the victim may be in India, and the server may be hosted elsewhere. Delay of even a few hours can allow funds to disappear through layered wallets, mule accounts and virtual assets. A Global Prosecution Agency could maintain an emergency digital evidence preservation unit, standardised warrants for member jurisdictions, and rapid prosecutor certification for cross-border data requests. Such powers would need strict judicial oversight, privacy protection and human-rights safeguards, but the alternative is worse: victims lose savings instantly while the justice system waits for files to travel through diplomatic channels.

The agency's mandate must be carefully limited to avoid overreach. It should focus on four categories: mass atrocity crimes, serious transnational organised

crime, large-scale financial and cybercrime, and crimes against vulnerable groups such as trafficking of persons, child exploitation and migrant smuggling. It should operate on the principle of complementarity: national prosecution first, global support when national systems are unwilling, unable, compromised or jurisdictionally blocked. It should not prosecute ordinary domestic crime. It should not become a tool for powerful States to target political opponents. It should have transparent appointment of prosecutors, judicial review of warrants, parliamentary-style oversight by member States, annual public reporting, independent ethics inspection, and a victims' participation office. The credibility of such an agency would depend not only on its power but on restraint, fairness and equal application.

Critics will argue that global prosecution may threaten sovereignty, but this criticism overlooks how sovereignty already fails when offenders escape accountability by crossing borders. A State that cannot bring back a fugitive, cannot access evidence abroad, and cannot freeze stolen money outside its territory has formal sovereignty but limited practical control. A Global Prosecution Agency would actually strengthen responsible sovereignty by giving States a professional mechanism to act together. The choice is not between national justice and global justice. The choice is between coordinated justice and borderless impunity.

The moral case is equally powerful. Victims of war crimes, trafficking, cyber-fraud and organised violence often experience justice as distance: distance from the court, distance from evidence, distance from the accused, and distance from power. A farmer cheated through an international digital loan fraud, a woman trafficked across borders, a child exploited through encrypted platforms, or a refugee abused by armed groups cannot be told that justice failed because files moved slowly between ministries. Law must travel at least as efficiently as crime. A Global Prosecution Agency would send a simple message: borders may divide jurisdiction, but they should not divide accountability.

The world has already built global systems for trade, banking, aviation, public health surveillance and climate negotiation. It is time to build a serious prosecutorial system for crimes that no State can defeat alone. The agency should begin with a coalition of willing States, linked with existing courts and police networks, and gradually expand through treaty accession. It should use technology, but remain governed by law; it should be independent, but accountable; it should respect national courts, but intervene when fragmentation defeats justice. The need of a Global Prosecution Agency is the need to modernise justice for a world where crime has already globalised. Without it, the international community will continue to celebrate cooperation after every rare success while millions of victims remain trapped in the silence between borders.

Views expressed are personal

SBI's consolidated net profit jumps 14% to ₹24,113 cr in Q1

On a standalone basis, the bank's net profit grew 10.23 per cent on-year to Rs 21,121.22 crore as against Rs 19,160.44 crore in April-June 2025

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: State Bank of India (SBI) on Friday reported 13.73 per cent rise in consolidated net profit at Rs 24,113 crore for June quarter as core income increased and provisions fell.

On a standalone basis, the country's largest lender's net profit grew 10.23 per cent on-year to Rs 21,121.22 crore as against Rs 19,160.44 crore in April-June 2025.

Chairman C S Setty said the bank is aiming for a 14-15 per cent rise in advances for the fiscal as against earlier expectation of 13-15 per cent.

In the June quarter, its core net interest income rose nearly 15 per cent to Rs 46,992 crore on the back of a 18.63 per cent rise in gross advances, while the domestic net interest margin contracted to 3 per cent.

Setty exuded confidence of maintaining domestic NIM at 3 per cent in FY27, and added that he does not see any changes in the broader lending and deposit rate trajectory during the remainder of the fiscal.

The bank's non-interest income dropped 9 per cent at Rs 15,293 crore, largely because of a 70 per cent drop in the forex or derivatives income.

Its deposit growth came in at 9.73 per cent and the share of



Chairman State Bank of India, C S Setty

the low-cost current and saving advances declined by 0.12 per cent on-year to 39.36 per cent. Setty said the bank's credit-deposit ratio has touched 74 per cent now and it can operate at 80 per cent as well.

A deposit growth of 10-11 per cent in FY27 will be sufficient to fund the advances, he said.

Managing Director Ashwini Kumar Tewari said the bank has corporate loan pipeline of nearly Rs 3.6 lakh crore coming from a variety of sectors.

The bank has so far executed three deals under the RBI's newly introduced acquisition financing framework, Tewari said, adding that the facility is helpful for the bank-

ing sector as it is able to attract clientele from sectors like the software industry which does not typically need bank finance in normal course.

The bank has mobilised \$6 billion under the FCNR(B) window since the beginning of the scheme and should be able to take the number to up to \$10 billion by the time the special window closes in September, Setty said.

Mopping up deposits from the diaspora will help reduce reliance on the high-cost bulk deposits domestically, he said, adding that the FCNR(B) accretion will not have any impact on the NIM trajectory for the bank.

From an asset quality perspective, the fresh slippages

HIGHLIGHTS

» 'The bank is aiming for a 14-15 per cent rise in advances for the fiscal as against earlier expectation of 13-15 per cent'

» In the June quarter, its core net interest income rose nearly 15% to Rs 46,992 crore on the back of a 18.63% rise in gross advances

came at Rs 7,046 crore, which was lower than Rs 7,945 crore in the year-ago period, but much higher than Rs 5,521 crore in the March quarter.

Gross non-performing assets ratio improved to 1.47 per cent as on June 30, from 1.49 per cent on March 31 this year and 1.83 per cent in the year-ago period.

Its provisions for non-performing assets reduced to Rs 3,359 crore in June quarter from Rs 4,934 crore in the year-ago period, but were higher than Rs 3,140 crore in the quarter-ago period.

The bank's overall capital adequacy ratio stood at 15.67 per cent as on June 30, including the core buffer of 12.89 per cent.

Parl Panel warns regulatory delays, funding gaps could hurt India's manufacturing drive

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The Department-related Parliamentary Standing Committee on Commerce, headed by Trinamool Congress MP Dola Sen, recently suggested wide-ranging changes to enhance the investment climate, streamline regulatory procedures, and foster industrialisation in India, adding that any funding issues or administrative delays could adversely affect India's plans for manufacturing.

The committee's 201st report, named "Doing Business in India: The Way Forward," and the 202nd report, which looked into the steps taken by the Government based on previous suggestions related to the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT), were adopted on August 5, this year.

The 2022 report evaluated the country's business environment through interactions with various ministries, industry associations, logistics companies, and policy experts. The members of the committee also went to Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh.

The panel lauded the government's attempts at making improvements in the business environment through measures like BRAP, NSWS, Jan Vishwas, regulatory compliance reforms and Cost of Regulation.

According to the report, due to these measures, over 47,000 compliance obligations have been simplified, digitised, decriminalised or abolished



The committee observed that India's ranking on the World Bank's ease-of-doing-business index went up from 142 in 2015 to 63 in 2020

altogether. The Jan Vishwas reform alone changed 784 provisions of 79 central laws.

The committee observed that India's ranking on the World Bank's ease-of-doing-business index went up from 142 in 2015 to 63 in 2020. In the same period, the Indian startup ecosystem grew phenomenally, and the number of startups registered rose from 502 in 2016 to more than 2.23 lakh in 2026. These enterprises together created about 23.3 lakh jobs.

Despite all of the above, the committee referred to several structural issues that keep many businesses.

According to the report, companies need to go through a very complex regulatory system, consisting of 1,536 laws, in excess of 69,000 compliance norms and over 6,600 statu-

tory compliances. According to industry members who appeared before the committee, overlapping regulation, inspections and inconsistency between central and state regulations add to the cost of compliance.

The committee also raised issues regarding delays in getting licenses and clearances, noting that a lack of automatic approvals keeps the efficiency of the National Single Window System low.

Delayed justice became another significant problem for India. The report noted that commercial litigation takes, on average, 1,445 days to get sorted out, thus undermining investor confidence and expansion plans. The committee stressed that a substantial number of backlogged cases in courts continues to pose a significant barrier to growth.

The procedures around taxation were also recognised as a problem area that required prompt action. The committee drew attention to the fragmented nature of tax deduction at source provisions, limitations on the use of reverse charge mechanism in the GST environment, and problems associated with the transfer of accumulated tax credit between different units of the same firm.

In order to solve these problems, the committee suggested conducting independent evaluations of proposed reforms, creating a single online compliance platform, implementing district-level business reforms, and increasing use of self-certification and a risk-based regulatory approach.

Furthermore, it suggested making the National Single Window System the single system for seeking regulatory approvals, renewal of licenses, submission of documents and monitoring of applications. This committee has also called for the creation of a deemed approval scheme whereby applications will automatically get approvals if any authority fails to take action within the stipulated time.

The committee also called for decriminalisation of minor procedural issues and also asked the government to use fines wherever necessary, in place of imprisonment. It also suggested having uniform national standards and mutual recognition of inspection certificates in case of renewable energy projects like solar parks, wind farms and battery energy storage facilities.

In its 202nd report, the committee examined 43 recommendations it made earlier to the DPIIT. According to the report, 24 recommendations have been accepted by the government, 12 have not been pursued any further and four have not been accepted by the committee while responses are pending on three recommendations.

The report appreciated the increase in the budget allocation to the ministry but warned of a huge gap between the estimated needs and budget allocation. The ministry, according to the report, has asked for Rs 16,581.10 crore but received Rs 11,970.83 crore, making a shortfall of Rs 4,610.27 crore.

COST OF NON-VEG THALI JUMPED BY 9%

Higher onion & cooking gas prices make Veg thali costlier by 4% in July

MUMBAI: The cost of a home-cooked vegetarian thali increased 4 per cent year-on-year in July, while a non-vegetarian thali became costlier by 9 per cent due to higher prices of onion, vegetable oil and cooking gas, as well as a sharp rise in chicken rates, according to a report released on Friday.

The average cost of a vegetarian thali rose as onion prices climbed 20 per cent from a year earlier, while vegetable oil and LPG cylinder prices increased 11 per cent and 10 per cent, respectively.

In the case of a non-vegetarian thali, a 14 per cent increase in rates of broiler chicken over and above the onion and cooking gas rates led to the steeper increase, Crisil Intelligence said in the report, adding that

broiler accounts for nearly half of the cost of a non-veg meal.

According to the report, onion prices remained elevated due to the arrival of higher-priced stored rabi stocks. Supplies were further tightened after unseasonal rainfall and hailstorms in Maharashtra during March and April damaged the late-season crop and stored inventories.

Vegetable oil and LPG prices increased amid supply disruptions and elevated energy prices linked to the ongoing West Asia conflict, it said.

The increase in thali costs was partially offset by a decline in potato and tomato prices, which fell 12 per cent and 2 per cent, respectively, from a year ago. Potato prices eased following a 2-3 per cent increase in

rabi production supported by higher acreage, while tomato prices remained lower due to delayed planting and higher market arrivals in July, the report said.

On a month-on-month basis, the vegetarian thali cost increased 2 per cent in July, primarily due to a 23 per cent jump in onion prices and a 4 per cent rise in potato prices. However, a 1 per cent decline in tomato prices and stable prices of other commodities prevented a sharper increase.

The cost of a non-vegetarian thali remained unchanged from June as an estimated 2 per cent decline in broiler prices, driven by moderation in demand, offset the impact of higher rates of other ingredients, the report added.

Rupee rises 5 paise to 95.17 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee settled with a 5 paise gain at 95.17 against the US dollar on Friday, backed by an inflow of foreign capital despite heightened risk aversion due to fragile negotiations between Iran & Oman over the Strait of Hormuz.

Forex traders said risk aversion in global markets due to uncertainty on the deal between Iran and Oman and an overnight jump in crude oil prices weighed on investor sentiments.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 95.27 against the greenback and traded in a range of 95.16-95.28 during the session. It eventually settled at 95.17, higher by 5 paise from its previous close.

On Thursday, the rupee depreciated 14 paise to close at 95.22 against the US dollar.

"We expect the rupee to trade with a slight negative bias on uncertainty over the deal between Iran and Oman over the Strait of Hormuz. However, markets may remain volatile over any decision over the weekend."

"Any positive news may support the rupee and vice versa. Traders may also take cues from the non-farm employment report from the US. USD-INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of 95 to 95.60," said Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset ShareKhan.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.90, down 0.02 per cent.

Stock mkts decline after two days of gains, dragged by banks & elevated crude oil prices

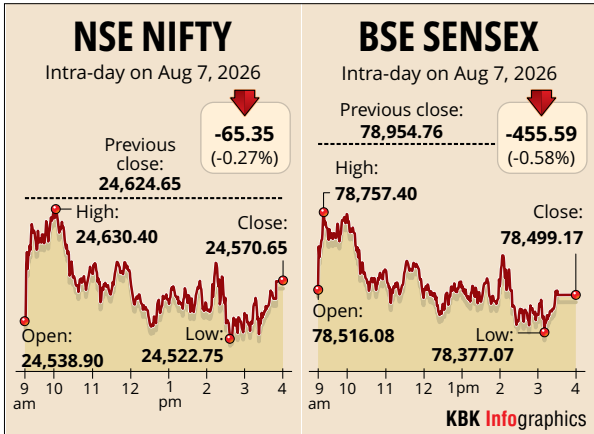
MUMBAI: Market benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty ended lower on Friday after two days of gains, dragged down by bank, financial stocks, and crude oil prices trading above \$80 per barrel mark.

The 30-share BSE Sensex dropped 455.59 points, or 0.58 per cent, to settle at 78,499.17. During the day, it tanked 577.69 points, or 0.73 per cent, to 78,377.07.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dipped 65.35 points, or 0.27 per cent, to end at 24,570.65. Intraday, it declined 113.25 points, or 0.45 per cent, to 24,522.75.

From the Sensex pack, Bajaj Finance tanked 5.90 per cent and Bajaj Finserv was down 4.18 per cent.

ICIIC Bank, Trent, Axis Bank, and Asian Paints were also among the laggards.



Tata Consultancy Services, Mahindra & Mahindra, State Bank of India, and Tech Mahindra were among the winners.

Bajaj Finance tumbled 5.90 per cent to end at Rs 1,082,

while Bajaj Finserv declined 4.18 per cent to Rs 2,001.90.

The BSE SmallCap Select index went up by 0.20 per cent and MidCap Select index edged higher by 0.19 per cent.

Among sectoral indices,

India's forex kitty swells \$10.5 bn to \$692.87 bn

MUMBAI: India's forex reserves jumped by \$10.512 billion to \$692.866 billion during the week ended July 31, the RBI said on Friday.

The overall kitty had jumped by \$6.118 billion to \$682.354 billion in the previous reporting week.

Reserves had expanded to an all-time high of \$728.494 billion during the week ended February 27 this year before the onset of the West Asia conflict, which led to several weeks of drop as the rupee came under pressure and the RBI had to intervene in the forex market through dollar sales.

For the week ended July 31, foreign currency assets, a major component of the reserves,

increased by \$8.75 billion to \$564.68 billion, the central bank's data showed.

Expressed in dollar terms, the foreign currency assets include effects of appreciation or depreciation of non-US units, such as the euro, pound, and yen, held in the foreign exchange reserves.

The value of gold reserves increased by \$1.685 billion to \$104.743 billion during the week, the RBI said.

The Special Drawing Rights (SDRs) were up by \$48 million at \$18.666 billion, the RBI said.

India's reserve position with the IMF also rose by \$28 million to \$4.778 billion at the end of the reporting week, according to the apex bank's data.

L&T's offshore business arm bags Major project orders from ONGC

NEW DELHI: L&T Energy Hydrocarbon Offshore, the offshore business arm of Larsen & Toubro, secured a batch of major orders from the ONGC for offshore engineering, procurement, construction, installation, and commissioning (EPCIC) projects off west coast.

According to project classification details, the orders fall under the "Major" classification, which encompasses contracts valued between Rs 5,000 crore and Rs 10,000 crore. Other project tiers include "Significant" (Rs 1,000 to 2,500 Cr), "Large" (Rs 2,500 to 5,000 Cr), "Mega" (Rs 10,000 to 15,000 Cr), and "Ultra-Mega" carrying a total value exceeding Rs 15,000 crore.



The awarded projects include the Pipeline Replacement Project (PRP-X) and the Well Head Platforms Project. Under the scope of PRP-X, the business will handle the EPCIC of multiple subsea pipeline segments. The assignment also entails associated modification works across the offshore fields owned by ONGC. Meanwhile, the Well Head Platforms Project requires the EPCIC of four

distinct Well Head Platforms off the west coast.

Commenting on the order win, Parthasarathi Chatterjee, Senior Vice President & Head - L&T Energy Hydrocarbon Offshore, said, "These orders reaffirm LTEH Offshore's position as a trusted partner in the development of India's offshore energy infrastructure." "They reflect the confidence customers place in our integrated EPCIC capabilities, extensive project execution experience and unwavering commitment to safety & operational excellence," Chatterjee added. "We look forward to delivering these projects to ONGC & contributing to the nation's energy aspirations." ANI

'Bihar emerges as national leader in smart metering, accounts for 70% of India's prepaid smart meters'

'The billing efficiency improved from 75.14 per cent in FY20 to 88.46 per cent in FY26'

NEW DELHI: Bihar showcased its power sector transformation and digital roadmap at the 7th CII International Energy Conference & Exhibition (IECE 2026), with Energy Secretary and Bihar State Power Holding Company Ltd (BSPHCL) CMD Ajay Yadav highlighting the state's leadership in smart metering.

Speaking at a session on demand response and digital power systems, Yadav said Bihar has installed 92 lakh prepaid smart meters, accounting for



nearly 70 per cent of all prepaid smart meters and around 30 per cent of total smart meter installations in India.

He said billing efficiency improved from 75.14 per cent in FY20 to 88.46 per cent in FY26, collection efficiency reached

100 per cent from 86 per cent, while AT&C losses declined from 35.12 per cent to 11.54 per cent. The ACS-ARR gap has also turned positive.

According to Yadav, prepaid smart meters have curbed power theft, eliminated arrears, improved billing efficiency and generated nearly 10 billion data points for demand forecasting. Bihar has also installed nearly two lakh distribution transformer meters for real-time monitoring and predictive maintenance.

The state is expanding IoT-based monitoring, GIS-enabled asset mapping, digital asset registers and an integrated customer relationship management platform. The Suvidha Bihar portal now offers 21 online consumer services.

Yadav said Bihar is promoting rooftop solar, feeder solarisation and the PM-KUSUM scheme while preparing its distribution network for higher renewable energy integration through smart grid technologies.

Powercom CMD holds meetings with industry & farmers' representatives

LUDHIANA: Punjab State Power Corporation Ltd (Powercom) CMD Dr. Basant Garg on Friday held separate meetings with representatives of industrial associations and farmers' organisations to discuss their grievances and suggestions, in line with Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann's directive to ensure reliable power supply.

Industrial bodies sought uninterrupted electricity, more technical staff, preventive maintenance, new substations and infrastructure upgrades. Garg assured them that all proposals would be examined and public-interest measures implemented on priority, adding



that industries would receive advance notice of emergency shutdowns.

Meeting farmers' representatives, he promised prompt resolution of complaints and urged them to approach him

directly if issues remained unresolved. Garg said Powercom is strengthening the distribution network under the Revamped Distribution Sector Scheme (RDSS) to improve reliability and consumer services.

India weathered Hormuz disruption without fuel shortages: Oil Min Puri

Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said India had moved beyond viewing energy security solely through the lens of access to hydrocarbons

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India successfully shielded consumers from supply disruptions triggered by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz earlier this year through diversified sourcing, expanded refining capacity and higher domestic production, Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said on Friday, while outlining the government's broader strategy to strengthen the country's energy security.

Addressing an industry event organised by the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII), Puri said India had moved beyond viewing energy security solely through the lens of access to hydrocarbons, citing diversified imports, strategic partnerships, infrastructure expansion and alternative fuels as key pillars of its approach.

"Today, I think we are in the happy situation of being able to say that, as far as India is concerned, we have moved on from that," he said.

He said India maintained uninterrupted fuel supplies despite disruptions to shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, a key global energy transit route.



Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri

The Iran war disrupted energy supplies through the strait. Pre-war, India imported as much as half its crude oil from countries using the strait as a transit. Also, 90 per cent of cooking gas LPG and 60 per cent of gas imports passed through the strait.

These supplies were disrupted, but India diversified its sources to prevent any dry-out anywhere in the country.

"I can say with a degree of confidence, not one station went dry, not one," Puri said, referring to the country's network of more than 1,07,000 fuel retail outlets.

According to Puri, India expanded its crude supply sources from 27 to 41 countries, increased its fuel retail

HIGHLIGHTS

» Also, 90 per cent of cooking gas LPG and 60 per cent of gas imports passed through the strait

» According to Puri, India expanded its crude supply sources from 27 to 41 countries

network from about 52,000 outlets in 2014 to around 1,07,000 currently, and broadened city gas distribution coverage from 55 geographical areas to 309.

The minister said domestic LPG production was increased to offset lower imports from Gulf suppliers affected by the disruption.

"We never ran short of crude oil supplies. We always had about 60 days (cover); there was no shortage," he said.

Puri also said the US had emerged as India's largest supplier of LPG following the disruption.

"Today, I am happy to inform you that the United States accounts for something like 67 per cent of our LPG

imports."

Looking beyond the immediate supply security, Puri highlighted the government's recently approved Rs 84,000 crore Samudra Manthan programme aimed at supporting deep-water oil and gas exploration.

"The government is not going to do the drilling. The drilling is going to be done by private players," he said, adding that the government would support up to 50 per cent of drilling costs or up to Rs 650 crore per well to encourage investment in high-risk offshore exploration.

Puri said India had opened previously restricted offshore acreage for exploration and expected further opportunities under future licensing rounds. He also highlighted the government's push to expand compressed biogas capacity and said India's ethanol blending programme continued to make progress.

Turning to recent concerns over ethanol-blended petrol, Puri dismissed suggestions of widespread fuel contamination, saying oil marketing companies had launched large-scale testing before complaints sur-

faced publicly.

"They found four cases out of 1,07,000 petrol pumps with six crores to seven crores consumers going every day. So obviously, someone out there is trying to place some things out of context."

Puri said inspection teams carried out extensive checks across the country. He argued that contamination incidents could occur in any fuel or product, but said the findings did not indicate a systemic issue.

The minister also defended the government's fuel pricing policy, saying excise duty reductions had helped cushion consumers from global volatility.

"In the last four years, if you look at an overall period, prices in India have largely come down. Why? Because the central government, thanks to very bold decision-making by the Prime Minister, decided to cut excise duty on fuel on three occasions in November 21, May 2022, and March 10, 2026."

He added that while retail petrol and diesel prices had risen modestly over a longer period, excise duty reductions had more than offset those increases.

REJECT CONTAMINATION CLAIMS

OMCs say nationwide tests find E20 petrol meets quality norms

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: State-run oil marketing companies (OMCs) said on Friday that additional nationwide testing of E20 petrol found no evidence to support claims of high moisture or chloride contamination, with fuel quality remaining within prescribed limits across the supply chain.

The intensified testing followed recent media reports alleging the presence of moisture and chloride in E20 (20 per cent ethanol blended petrol).

Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) in a joint statement said the exercise covered the entire supply chain and reaffirmed that fuel quality remained "consistently well within prescribed limits."

"Contrary to certain assertions being made, there is no evidence of any alarm on account of fuel contamination validated by extensive and scientifically designed tests," the companies said.

The three OMCs said the government has prescribed stringent chloride specifications for ethanol used in petrol blending and has put in place high-frequency monitoring at refineries, distilleries, depots, terminals and retail outlets to ensure compliance.



The companies said they have also strengthened quality surveillance by conducting water-ingress and density tests 8-12 times a day at every retail outlet, deploying mobile fuel quality testing laboratories and independently validating results through fuel laboratories.

More than 100 additional petrol samples collected from refineries showed chloride levels at or below 1 part per million (ppm), while ethanol samples from 80 distilleries tested over the past 10 days recorded chloride content below 3 ppm, OMCs said.

More than 80 samples collected from depots and terminals across the country also showed chloride content below 3 ppm, they said.

At retail outlets, more than 160 E20 samples tested over the past few days recorded chloride levels in the 0-3 ppm range, "contrary to the claims of several hundred ppm," OMCs said.

The surveillance identified two isolated instances of ele-

vated chloride levels, where supplies were immediately suspended pending root-cause analysis and corrective action before restoration.

The companies said about 90,000 retail outlets had begun mandatory inspections of underground storage tanks, with checks conducted 8-12 times daily. No water ingress had been detected so far.

Speaking at a CII event earlier on Friday, Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri dismissed concerns over E20 fuel quality, saying attempts were being made to "create some controversy" around the country's ethanol blending programme.

Puri said the ministry had begun intensified testing about two weeks before a letter dated July 28 raised concerns over fuel quality, adding that dedicated teams had conducted extensive checks across fuel retail outlets.

"They formed crack teams... What did they find? They found four cases out of 107,000 petrol pumps... So obviously, someone out there is trying to place some things out of context," Puri said.

The minister said India has about 107,000 fuel retail outlets serving an estimated 6-7 crore customers a day, adding that contamination, where it occurs, can affect any product and isolated cases should not be viewed as evidence of a systemic problem.

PFC net profit rises to ₹8,998 cr in Q1

NEW DELHI: State-owned Power Finance Corporation on Friday reported a marginal rise in its consolidated net profit to Rs 8,998 crore in the June quarter. The company's total revenue from operations stood at Rs 28,526.86 crore in the quarter against Rs 28,539.04 crore.

"Rs 8,998 crore consolidated profit after tax (net profit) recorded in Q1 FY27 vs Rs 8,981 crore in Q1 FY26," a company statement said.

The consolidated loan asset

book stands at Rs 11,60,133 crore as of June 30, 2026.

PFC Group continues to be the largest renewable financier in the country, with a renewable loan book at Rs 1,63,184 crore as of June 30, 2026.

The consolidated net worth (including non-controlling interest) was Rs 1,87,106 crore as of June 30, 2026. On the asset quality front, net credit impaired asset ratio (stage III) slipped 18 bps year-on-year to 0.13 per cent in Q1 FY27.

Gross credit impaired asset (Stage III) ratio also declined by 81 bps to 0.66 per cent from 1.47 per cent a year earlier.

The board, in its meeting on Friday, also approved an interim dividend of Rs 3.90/share in Q1.

On a standalone basis, the company recorded a net profit of Rs 4,745 crore in Q1 FY27 against Rs 4,502 crore a year ago. Loan Asset Book stood at Rs 5,70,045 crore as of June 30, 2026, on a standalone basis.

Titan Q1 net profit soars 62.87% to ₹1,777 crore

NEW DELHI: Titan Company Ltd on Friday reported a 40.3 per cent increase in revenue to Rs 20,787 crore in the June quarter of FY27, driven by strong growth in its jewellery business. Consolidated net profit rose 62.87 per cent to Rs 1,777 crore from Rs 1,091 crore in the year-ago period.

The company's flagship Jewellery segment, which contributed nearly 91 per cent of sales,

recorded 29.73 per cent growth at Rs 19,002 crore, supported by festive and Akshaya Tritiya demand, exchange programmes and higher gold prices.

Revenue from Watches & Wearables increased 21.2 per cent to Rs 1,543 crore, while Eyecare revenue rose 21.42 per cent to Rs 289 crore. Titan added 33 jewellery stores during the quarter to expand its retail presence.

OIL reports highest ever Standalone PAT of ₹2,870 crore in April-June qtr

NEW DELHI: State-owned Oil India Limited (OIL), declared its financial results for Q1 FY27, in its 583rd meeting of the Board of Directors held on Friday.

The Company registered its highest ever Standalone profit after tax (PAT) at Rs 2,870 crore in Q1 FY27 vis-à-vis Rs 813 crore in Q1 FY26, 2.5 times YoY growth supported by 11 per cent growth in crude oil production and crude oil price realisation of

\$98.73/bbl in Q1FY27.

OIL achieved a Consolidated PAT of Rs 4,027 crore in Q1 FY27 vis-à-vis Rs 2,047 crore in Q1 FY26, growth of 97 per cent YoY.

In its efforts towards ensuring Nation's Energy Security, the Company produced 0.950 MMT of crude oil from its matured oilfields in Q1 FY27 vis-à-vis 0.853 MMT in Q1 FY26. On 27th June, 2026, OIL

has achieved highest ever daily crude oil production of 10,921 MT (84,109 bbl).

Oil India Limited's material subsidiary NRL achieved a robust 167 per cent growth in profit after tax, rising to Rs 1,305 crore in Q1FY27 from Rs 488 crore in Q1FY26 with a GRM of \$ 35.95/bbl vis-à-vis \$ 5.02/bbl and Distillate Yield of 87.58 per cent vis-à-vis 85.38 per cent.

Sport

A hiccup before the real Test

Indian bowlers make comeback after poor first session; SLC XI post 363/8

COLOMBO: Indian bowling unit got some rough treatment from Sri Lanka's Gen-Next batters before Kuldeep Yadav-led spinners scripted a recovery in the final session as the hosts posted 363 for 8 to end their first innings on the opening day of the three-day warm-up game here on Friday.

Since the match doesn't have first-class status -- each team will bat 90 overs on days one and two and 45 overs each on the final day.

However at the end of the first day, head coach Gautam Gambhir and skipper Shubman Gill, who didn't take the field due to an impact injury that he suffered during a training session, will have a lot to ponder.

If day's performance is an indicator, off-spinner Saransh Jain (0/54 in 11 overs) will find it difficult to be in contention with both Kuldeep (2/76 in 18 overs) and Manav Suthar (1/30 in 11 overs) doing well. Sealed Ravindra Jadeja (2/64 in 15 overs) looked out of sync despite getting a couple of wickets.

Playing a red-ball game after five weeks, the pacers were understandably rusty while the spinners despite sharing bulk of the spoils didn't look menacing enough till Kuldeep found his mojo and asked a few probing



Manav Suthar was the best of the India bowlers on show

BCCL

questions.

Otherwise, the Day One primarily belonged to young island batters, some of whom have just started off with their Test careers, looked at ease while facing the Indian attack on a mostly benign Nondescripts Cricket Club track which provided some purchase for Kuldeep towards the fag end of the day.

There were two Sri Lankan batters, whose batting stood on

the first day.

The first one was opener Nishan Fernando (66 off 65), who played the senior Indian pacers -- Mohammed Siraj (0/44 in 13 overs), and Prasidh Krishna (0/32 in 8 overs) -- with ease.

Gurnoor Brar (1/49 in 12 overs) was the only pacer who looked incisive. Fernando had recently played Tests on the tour to the West Indies.

The 110-run opening stand

with Ravindu Rasantha (71 off 143 balls) had Indian pacers and spinners scurrying for cover as they scored runs at a quick clip before an unfortunate mix-up led to Fernando's run-out. The second one was southpaw Sonal Dinusha (52 off 72 balls), who displayed admirable technique and the only batter in the middle-order who read Kuldeep from the wrist and hit a regal straight six.

AGENCIES

Free entry for fans

COLOMBO: Cricket fans will be allowed free entry during Sri Lanka's upcoming two-Test series against India, starting August 15 in Galle, the country's cricket board announced on Friday.

"Sri Lanka Cricket (SLC) wishes to announce that public admission to the upcoming Test Series between Sri Lanka and India will be free of charge thus providing cricket fans with an excellent opportunity to witness world-class Test cricket," SLC stated.

The first match will be held at the Galle International Stadium while the second game will be held at the SSC in Colombo from August 23-27. "Sri Lanka Cricket warmly invites cricket enthusiasts, young aspiring cricketers, families, and sports fans from across the country to take advantage of this initiative and experience the excitement of international Test cricket between Sri Lanka and India," it further stated.

AGENCIES

ST. LOUIS: Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa clinched his maiden Saint Louis Rapid & Blitz title in emphatic fashion, sealing the championship with a round to spare here.

The 20-year-old finished with 23.5 points, comfortably ahead of Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan, the contender for the world championship title this year.

Not losing any games on the final day of the last rapid and blitz tournament in the Grand Chess Tour (GCT), Praggnanandhaa jumped to second spot in the GCT which almost guarantees him a place in the grand finale scheduled later this year.

The Indian will just have to keep up his form in the last tournament of the season, the Sinquefeld Cup, which will be played under the Classical format from August 10 to 19.

After winning the rapid section with a marginal one-point lead against Sindarov, Praggnanandhaa lost only one game in the blitz and scored the requisite victories to end up with 11.5 points out of a possible 18.

Sindarov, who was trailing Praggnanandhaa by a full point after the rapid section, had to be content with the second spot



R Praggnanandhaa with the trophy

FIDE

I am super happy with the result (winning the St Louis Rapid & Blitz) and overall about the game quality

R Praggnanandhaa

on 22 points whereas Wesley So of the United States came third, scoring 20 points overall.

Praggnanandhaa jumped to second spot in the overall GCT rankings following his triumph

and much would depend on how he performs in the Sinquefeld Cup starting on the weekend.

The withdrawal of Alireza Firouzja of France from the GCT has impacted positively on the lone Indian on the tour. Firouzja cited scheduling issues ahead of the last two events and his entire points earned thus far were removed as per the pre-agreement.

"I am super happy with the result (winning the St Louis Rapid & Blitz) and overall about the game quality. This is the first major rapid and blitz victory, so I'm really happy about it," said Praggnanandhaa on "X" after the triumph in the elite 10-man field.

AGENCIES

Ashmita, Rakshitha book all-Indian Korea semis

ASAN: India's Ashmita Chalhah and Rakshitha Ramraj will square off in the women's singles semifinals of the USD 250,000 Korea Masters Super 300 badminton tournament after registering hard-fought wins in their respective quarter-finals here on Friday.

World No. 50 Ashmita produced the biggest upset of the tournament so far, shocking top seed and World No. 22 Hina Akechi of Japan 20-22



21-15 21-19 in a gripping quar-

terfinal at the Asan Yi Sun-sin

Gymnasium.

The victory also helped the Indian avenge a defeat in their only previous meeting at the Malaysia Super 100 last year.

Rakshitha, meanwhile, came back from a game down to upset third seed and compatriot Tanvi Sharma 18-21 21-19 21-18 in a contest that lasted over an hour. It was her fourth win over Tanvi, who had claimed her maiden BWF title at Taipei Open last week.

AGENCIES



JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE
DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F),
email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
Hue and Cry Notice
Rule No. 712/191

SHO P/S Bagh-e-Bahu, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Sabzar Ahmed Dar S/O Abdul Hamid Dar R/O Verinag, Srinagar is evading his arrest/wanted in case FIR No. 40/2001 U/S 391 RPC P/S Bagh-e-Bahu, Jammu. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded. Moreover, the Hon'ble Court has also issued General Warrant of arrest U/S 512 Cr.PC in respect of said accused person.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name : Sabzar Ahmed Dar
S/O : Abdul Hamid Dar
Address : Verinag, Srinagar

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1.DPO, Jammu :0191-2547807,0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3.PCR Jammu :0191-2605949
4.SP City South : 0191-2433778
5. SDPO City East :01912474700
6.P/S Bagh-e-Bahu :0191-24559777

Sd/- Sr. Superintendent of Police Jammu

DIP No:DIP/J-7623/26



ARCHIVAL RESEARCH AND IDENTIFICATION OF LAND ASSOCIATED WITH DHR

E-Tender Notice No: GEM/2026/B/7849594; **Dated:** 30-07-2026.

E-Tender are invited by the undersigned for the following work:

Name of Work : Archival Research and Identification of Land Associated with Darjeeling Himalayan Railway (DHR) / Cart Road in Compliance with CCMP, ICOMOS, WHC Reports/Guidelines. **Tender Value:** ₹1,12,10,000/-; **Earnest Money:** ₹2,06,050/-; **Date & time of closing tender at 12:00 hrs. and opening of tender at 12:30 hrs. on 20-08-2026.** For details please visit in the website [https:// GeM.gov.in](https://GeM.gov.in).

Director/DHR/Kurseong

NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY
Serving Customers With A Smile



NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY
E-Tendering Tender Notice No.: 42/2026

Divisional Railway Manager (Engg.) North Eastern Railway Izatnagar for and behalf of president of India invites "OPEN" e-tender through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work:

S.No.-01, Description of works: (1) IZN Div.-Provision of LHS (Limited Height Subway) in lieu of LC No. 67/C (for elimination of LC) in the jurisdiction of ADEN/FGR. (2) Provision of LHS (Limited Height Subway) in lieu of LC No. 147/C (for elimination of LC) in the jurisdiction of ADEN/FGR. Approx. Value: ₹ 25,99,81,076.93, E.M.D Money: ₹ 51,99,600/-, Cost of Tender Forms (Rs): NIL, Completion time/period from the date of issue of acceptance letter: 12 Months.

(1) On line e-tender can be submitted upto 15.00 hrs of dated 28-08-2026. (2) For Full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways IREPS website www.ireps.gov.in Divisional Railway Manager (Engg.) CPROW-269 Izatnagar

Never travel on roof and foot boards.



UJVN LTD.
H.O.:'UJJWAL', Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dohradun-248006
Telephone: 0135 - 2763808, Fax 0135-2763508
CIN No.U40101UR2001SGC225868, Website: www.ujvn.ltd.gov.in



e-Tender Notice Dated 07.08.2026

Office of the Executive Engineer (Civil), Arakot-Tiuni Project, Dakpathar, invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:

Tender No.03/UJVNL/EE(Civil)/Arakot-Tiuni/2026-27

Name of work-"Division of Forest Land for Arakot-Tiuni Hydro Electric Project (3X27 MW ≈81 MW), including Preparation and Processing of Forest Clearance proposal, obtaining requisite all Approvals/Consents from Concerned Central and State Government Authorities, and Facilitation of Grant of Stage-I and Stage-II Forest Clearance in favour of UJVN Limited in District Uttarkashi, Uttarakhand."

Estimated cost -Rs. 3199845.00 (excluding GST)

Date of availability of bid document on website - 10.08.2026 at 17:00 Hrs.

Last date for submission of bids on website - 25.08.2026 up to 17:00 Hrs.

For full & further details, kindly visit e-procurement portal <http://uktenders.gov.in>" **Executive Engineer (Civil)**

"Avoid Wasteful use of Electricity"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Kajal W/o Manish R/o Jhuggi No.-328, AU-Block, Pitampura, Delhi**, has committed (or) is suspected to have committed) the offence in **Case Reg. No. 292/2019, U/S 33/38 Delhi Excise Act, PS Maurya Enclave, North West Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Kajal** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Kajal** has absconded (or) is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Kajal** the said accused of **Case Reg. No. 292/2019, U/S 33/38 Delhi Excise Act, PS Maurya Enclave, North West Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **16.09.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Anuradha Jindal
Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate,
North-West Distt., Rohini Courts, Delhi



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Notice No. AGC-EL-GSU-T-04-26 Date : 05.08.2026

E- Tender Notice

Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer (Gati Shakti), North Central Railway, Agra on behalf of President of India invites "Open Tender" through online only (E-Tendering) for the following works.

Tender No. : AGC-EL-GSU-T-04-26 | Approximate Cost of work : Rs. 28431307.86/-

Name of work with its location & Completion Period : Electrical General work in connection with provision of Shunting Neck (GXN end) and Pit Line at Agra Cantt.

Closing date of Tender : 27.08.2026 at 12:00

Period of completion : 12 Months

For complete information and to participate in the tender, please visit the Indian Railways website at www.ireps.gov.in. Tenders can be submitted exclusively via the Indian Railways web portal (www.ireps.gov.in) until 12:00 Hrs. on 27.08.2026 1813/26 (C)

[f](#) North central railways [www.mcr.indianrailways.gov.in](#) [X](#) @ CPRONC



APPENDIX IV-A
Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Property

E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(b) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described Immovable Property mortgaged to **Sammaan Capital Limited ("SCL")** [formerly known as Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd. ("IHFL")] [CIN : L65922DL2005PLC136029] and **Indiabulls Asset Reconstruction Company Limited [CIN : U67110MH2006PLC305312]** acting as a Trustee of **Indiabulls ARC-XXXI Trust** (both SCL and IARCL) are jointly and severally referred to as ("Secured Creditor"), the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "as is where is", "as what is" and "whatever there is" basis on 09.09.2026 from 05.00 P.M. to 06.00 P.M., for recovery of the following amounts due to SCL and IARCL : **DUES OF SAMMAAN CAPITAL LIMITED** (formerly known as Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd.):

S. No.	Loan Account Number	Outstanding amounts (In Rs.) as on 28.07.2026
1.	HHLNOD00410280	Rs. 29,60,140/- (Rupees Twenty Nine Lakh Sixty Thousand One Hundred Forty only)

DUES OF INDIABULLS ASSET RECONSTRUCTION COMPANY LIMITED :

S. No.	Loan Account Number	Outstanding amounts (In Rs.) as on 28.07.2026
1.	R008XXXI (Old Loan Account No. HHENOD00410280)	Rs. 4,12,427/- (Rupees Four Lakh Twelve Thousand Four Hundred Twenty Seven only)

The Loan Account No. HHENOD00410280, along with all right(s), title(s), interest(s), underlying security(ies), pledge(s) and / or guarantee(s) including the Immovable Property, has been assigned by Sammaan Capital Limited ("SCL") [formerly known as Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd. ("IHFL")] to and in favour of Indiabulls Asset Reconstruction Company Limited ("IARCL") vide Assignment Agreement dated 21.08.2023 and the same has been renumbered by IARCL and bears new Loan Account No. R008XXXI. Consequently, IARCL has also become a Secured Creditor for the said assigned Loan Account. IARCL has given its consent to SCL to issue this Notice of Sale.

The amounts mentioned in both the tables given above are pending towards the respective Loan Accounts of SCL and IARCL, by way of outstanding principal, arrears (including accrued late charges) and interest till 28.07.2026 with applicable future interest in terms of the Loan Agreement(s) and other related loan document(s) w. e. f. 29.07.2026 along with legal expenses and other charges due and payable to the Secured Creditor from **RAJINDER SINGH and MUKESH DEVI**.

The Reserve Price for the Immovable Property will be Rs. 17,10,000/- (Rupees Seventeen Lakh Ten Thousand only) and the Earnest Money Deposit ("EMD") will be Rs. 1,71,000/- (Rupees One Lakh Seventy One Thousand only). i. e. equivalent to 10% of the Reserve Price.



DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

FLAT No. F 3, FIRST FLOOR, REAR LEFT HAND SIDE, PLOT No. A 79, SHALIMAR GARDEN, MAIN SAHIBABAD, GHAZIABAD, UTTAR PRADESH - 201010.

For detailed terms and conditions of sale, please refer to the link provided on the website of the Secured Creditor i.e. www.sammaancapital.com; Contact No : 0124 - 6910910, +91 7065451024; E-mail id : auctionhelpline@sammaancapital.com. For bidding, log on to www.auctionfocus.in.

Date : 29.07.2026
Place : GHAZIABAD

sd/-
AUTHORIZED OFFICER
SAMMAAN CAPITAL LIMITED
(Formerly known as INDIABULLS HOUSING FINANCE LTD.)



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No. JHS/Commercial-e-Auction/26/75 Date: 05.08.2026

E-AUCTION NOTICE

On Behalf of The President of India, The Divisional Railway Manager, (Commercial) Jhansi invites e-auction as per categories given as under:-

Category: Advertisement **Catalogue No.:** JHS-NFR-ADV-75

Asset Details: E-AUCTION FOR CONTRACT UNDER

1. Advertisement right on exterior portion (Full Face) through Vinyl wrapping of the coaches of following Train No : 11801/02, 11123/24 & 22195/96-022199/02200-22197/98

Auction Start : 19.08.2026 at 11:00 hrs **Auction End: 19.08.2026 at 11:50 hrs**

Note:- Prospective bidders are requested to visit e-Auction Leasing module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number. 1814/26 (D)

[f](#) North central railways [www.mcr.indianrailways.gov.in](#) [X](#) @ CPRONCR



JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE
DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F),
email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
Hue and Cry Notice
Rule No. 712/191

SHO P/S Bagh-e-Bahu, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Liaqat Ali S/O Mohd Shaif R/O R.S. Pura is evading his arrest/wanted in case FIR No. 58/2012 U/S 188 RPC, 3PCA Act & 4/25 Arms Act of P/S Bagh-e-Bahu, Jammu. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded. Moreover, the Hon'ble Court has also issued General Warrant of arrest U/S 512 Cr.PC in respect of said accused person.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name : Liaqat Ali
S/O : Mohd Shaif
Address : R.S. Pura

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1.DPO, Jammu :0191-2547807,0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3.PCR Jammu :0191-2605949
4.SP City South : 0191-2433778
5. SDPO City East :01912474700
6.P/S Bagh-e-Bahu :0191-24559777

Sd/- Sr. Superintendent of Police Jammu

DIP No:DIP/J-7625/26

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSONS

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused persons **1. Ajay Kumar S/o Santosh R/o H. No. 44, Harijan Basti, Kondli, Delhi & 2. Sagar S/o Megh Singh R/o H. No. F-19, Harijan Basti, Kondli, Delhi** has committed (or) are suspected to have committed) the offence case FIR No. 72/2019 u/s 356/379/411/34 IPC at P.S. Gazipur, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **1. Ajay Kumar & 2. Sagar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **1. Ajay Kumar & 2. Sagar** have absconded (or) are concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s 82 Cr. P.C. have been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **1. Ajay Kumar & 2. Sagar** accused of FIR No. 72/2019 u/s 356/379/411/34 IPC at P.S. Gazipur, Delhi are required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **11.09.2026**.

By Order
Shri Sachin
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03 (East)
Room No. 16,
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC / 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Arpit Shukla S/o Rajender Shukla R/O D-51A, P-122, Pillanji Village, Sarojini Nagar, South-West, Delhi**, has committed (or) is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 144/2025, U/S 129/55 Gambling Act, PS Sarojini Nagar, South West Distt., New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Arpit Shukla** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Arpit Shukla** has absconded (or) is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Arpit Shukla** the said accused of **FIR No. 144/2025, U/S 129/55 Gambling Act, PS Sarojini Nagar, South West Distt., New Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **11.09.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Vijayshree Rathore
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05,
Court No.-13, 1st Floor, Main Building,
Patala House Courts, New Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C/ 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Nasim S/o Abdul Wahid R/o Plot No. 426, Ground to Second Floor, Kakrola Dairy, New Delhi** has Committed (or) is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CT. Case No. 489/2024, U/s 135 Indian Electricity Act, P.S. Dwarka North, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Nasim** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Nasim** has absconded (or) is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Nasim of CT. Case No. 489/2024, U/s 135 Indian Electricity Act, P.S. Dwarka North, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **07.09.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Harleen Singh
Additional District & Session Judge
South West, Court No. 609 Special Court Electricity
Dwarka Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.PC.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Adil, S/o Mehraj Ali, R/o 2086, Kaka Chote Lal Turqman Gate, Chandni Mehral, Delhi** has committed (or) is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 268/2017, U/s 354/506/509 IPC, P.S. Jafrabad, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Adil** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Adil** has absconded (or) is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Adil** accused of **FIR No. 268/2017, U/s 354/506/509 IPC, P.S. Jafrabad, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **22.09.2026**.

By Order - Ms. Pooja
Judicial Magistrate First Class (Mahila Court)-03
Shahdara District, Room No. 08, 2nd Floor
DP/10470/NE/2026
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi



APPENDIX IV-A
Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Property

E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(b) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described Immovable Property mortgaged to **Sammaan Capital Limited** (formerly known as Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd.) [CIN : L65922DL2005PLC136029] ("Secured Creditor"), the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "as is where is", "as is what is" and "whatever there is" basis on 09.09.2026 from 05.00 P.M. to 06.00 P.M., for recovery of Rs. 27,83,295/- (Rupees Twenty Seven Lakh Eighty Three Thousand Two Hundred Ninety Five only) pending towards **Loan Account No. HHLNOD00423970**, by way of outstanding principal, arrears (including accrued late charges) and interest till 28.07.2026 with applicable future interest in terms of the Loan Agreement and other related loan document(s) w. e. f. 29.07.2026 along with legal expenses and other charges due to the Secured Creditor from **ANKITAA GUPTA @ ANKITA GUPTA and RAVINDRA KUMAR JAISWAL**.

The Reserve Price of the Immovable Property will be Rs. 40,06,000/- (Rupees Forty Lakh Six Thousand only) and the Earnest Money Deposit ("EMD") will be Rs. 4,00,600/- (Rupees Four Lakh Six Hundred only) i. e. equivalent to 10% of the Reserve Price.



DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

APARTMENT No. 1602, ADMEASURING 860 SQUARE FEET ON 16TH FLOOR, TOWER - B IN THE PROJECT KNOWN AS MARINA SUITES, GH-31, ADITYA PARK TOWN, NH -24, GHAZIABAD -201001, UTTAR PRADESH.

For detailed terms and conditions of sale, please refer to the link provided on the website of the Secured Creditor i.e. www.sammaancapital.com; Contact No : 0124- 6910910, +91 7065451024; E-mail id : auctionhelpline@sammaancapital.com. For bidding, log on to www.auctionfocus.in.

sd/-
AUTHORIZED OFFICER
SAMMAAN CAPITAL LIMITED (Formerly known as INDIABULLS HOUSING FINANCE LTD.)

Date : 30.07.2026
Place : GHAZIABAD

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.PC. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Gajender Dass, S/o Sheeta Dass, R/o H.No. A-1, Block-4, Flat No. 126, Indian Airlines Colony, Vasant Vihar, Delhi** has committed (or) is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 285/21, U/s 420/468/471 IPC, P.S. Kirti Nagar, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Gajender Dass** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Gajender Dass** has absconded (or) is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Gajender Dass** accused of **FIR No. 285/21, U/s 420/468/471 IPC, P.S. Kirti Nagar, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **14.09.2026**.

By Order - Ms. Vasundhara Azad
Chief Judicial Magistrate, West District
DP/10702/WD/2026
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.PC. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Arti, D/o Sunny, R/o Khasra No. 376, Block-J, Gali No. 3, Khadda Colony, Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or) is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 368/2023, U/s 33/38 D. Ex. Act, P.S. Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Arti** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Arti** has absconded (or) is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Arti** accused of **FIR No. 368/2023, U/s 33/38 D. Ex. Act, P.S. Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **14.09.2026**.

By Order - Sh. Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07, North
DP/10934/ON/2026
Room No. 06, Rohini Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.PC)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Virender @ Vihan, S/o Sobarn R/o A-32, Chhota Chowk, Near Kheda Dev Mandir ke Samne, Mandawali, Delhi** has committed (or) is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.288/2019 u/s 380 IPC, P.S. Mandawali, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Virender @ Vihan** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Virender @ Vihan** has absconded (or) is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Virender @ Vihan** of **FIR No.288/2019 u/s 380 IPC, P.S. Mandawali, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **23.09.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Sachin
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
East District, Court No.16
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi
DP/10515/ED/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) **Bablu, S/o: Adab Singh R/o: E-49 Gali No. 3, Vikrant Chowk Mohan Garden, Delhi** has committed (or) is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 555/2022, U/s: 454/380/411/34 IPC, PS: Ranhola, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Bablu**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Bablu**, has absconded (or) is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Bablu, of FIR No. 555/2022, U/s: 454/380/411/34 IPC, PS: Ranhola, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **01.12.2026**.

By Order
Shri Ankit Karan Singh
Judicial Magistrate First Class
Tis Hazari Courti, Delhi
DP/9629/OD/2026
(Court Matter)



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDERING TENDER NOTICE

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-Tr-2026-188

Description of work: Supplying and stacking of SKV Welding Portion for 52Kg, 60Kg & R 260 (60Kg) rails with improved preheating welding technology namely compressed air petrol / LPG along with Single shot crucible fitted and with use of three piece prefabricated moulds with Automatic Tapping Thimble (ATT) technology under jurisdiction of Jhansi Division.

Approx Cost: ₹27439695.14 **Earnest Money:** ₹548800.00

Date of closing Tender: 27.08.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

Date of completion / period from issue acceptance letter: 18 Months

* Tender on line can be submitted upto 15:00 hrs. on 27.08.2026. * For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in 1807/26 (PH)

[f](#) North central railways [X](#) @ CPRONCR [www.mcr.indianrailways.gov.in](#)

NATIONAL HANDLOOM DAY

BOLLYWOOD CELEBS & THEIR LOVE FOR LOOM

For several Bollywood personalities, handloom is as much about emotion as it is about fashion



OUR CORRESPONDENT

Actress Konkona Sen Sharma is, without a doubt, one of Bollywood's strongest supporters of handloom. Talking about her love for handloom, the 'Wake Up Sid' actress said that 'handloom is her mother's home'. While growing up, she saw handlooms everywhere because her mother, veteran actress-filmmaker Aparna Sen, has also been a strong advocate of handloom. Then there is Vidya Balan, who has made handwoven sarees almost synonymous with her public persona. She said that every detail in a handloom carries the signature of an Indian artisan. Actresses such as Shefali Shah, Ratna Pathak Shah and Dia Mirza have also embraced Indian handlooms, which are renowned for their craftsmanship. Handloom is like a legacy. Handloom sarees do not follow trends; they are more of a habit. On

National Handloom Day, we list Bollywood celebrities who swear by handloom, not merely to pose in Indian weaves on their social media reels, but to make it a part of their everyday lives.

VIDYA BALAN

If we are talking about handloom sarees, there is one celebrity who has made handwoven sarees a part of her identity. Vidya Balan. Once known for her faux pas' fashion, Vidya rediscovered her strong sense of style with handloom sarees. Wherever she goes, she makes sure to use her voice to champion Indian weavers and their craftsmanship.

KONKONA SEN SHARMA



Konkona Sen Sharma has grown up around handloom, as her mother, the celebrated actress and filmmaker Aparna Sen, has been promoting India's handloom traditions and heritage since she entered the film industry. And Konkona, much like her effortless performances on screen, keeps her handloom style simple. Whether she is attend-

ing a red-carpet event or a social gathering, she can often be seen promoting ethical fashion.

DIA MIRZA



The 'Rehnaa Hai Terre Dil Mein' actress has always expressed her love for handloom sarees. She has been seen wearing handwoven sarees on various occasions, adding a touch of elegance to her looks.

SHEFALI SHAH



Shefali Shah is not only one of the strongest performers in Indian cinema today, but also a

strong supporter of handloom. Sharing her love for the craft, the 'Dil Dhadakne Do' actress revealed how the handloom saree from her wedding trou-seau still carries the 'scent of new love'. "This one has been with me for years. That's the magic of handloom. Each time you wear it, you find a new magic that will continue growing alongside," she said.

RATNA PATHAK SHAH



"I don't like to spend more than Rs 10,000 on clothes. But I buy sarees. I love textiles. I really feel what we have in India in terms of textiles is extraordinary. I am willing to spend more than Rs 10,000 if it's a handwoven saree," said veteran actress Ratna Pathak Shah in an interview, speaking about her love for handloom. She expressed her respect for the human labour that goes into creating handwoven textiles. She has also advocated not only for the importance of Indian textiles but also for the need to preserve them.



Aditi calls Ranbir Kapoor 'incredible'

He's getting positive feedback for his role in 'Ramayana: The Introduction'

Hydari also expressed her admiration for Sanjay Leela Bhansali

most convincing actors in Bollywood, is also getting positive feedback from the industry and critics alike. Aditi, who worked with Ranbir in 'Rockstar', also praised his co-star's acting talent in a recent interview. When asked about her experience working with Ranbir Kapoor in 'Rockstar', Aditi shared. "Working with Ranbir was mad. He's incredible, so incredible. He's one of my favourite actors and he's so present. He can convince you of anything."

In an interview with 'Humans of Bombay', Aditi also expressed her admiration for Sanjay Leela Bhansali and being on his sets. She recalled, "I finished shooting a love story with Mani Ratnam and three days later, I was on Sanjay's set. I walked onto the set and of course, I was mesmerised because it was just like, 'What is this world?'" AGENCIES

TED SARANDOS ON 'OPERATION SAFED SAGAR'

'It is a celebration of 10 years of Netflix in India'

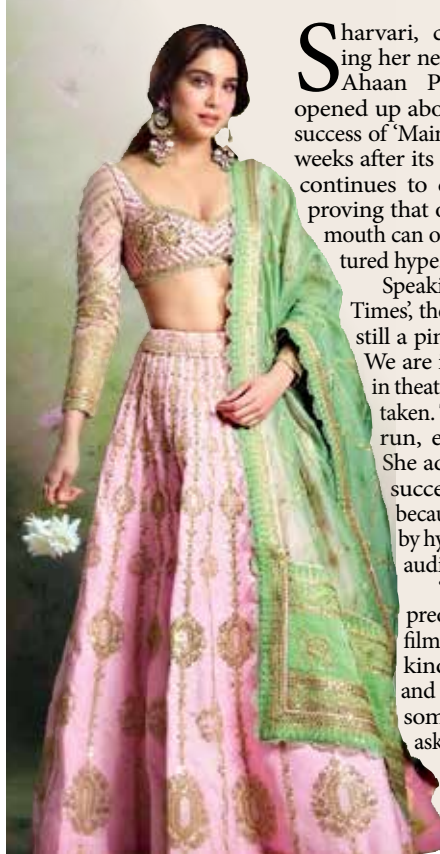
Netflix's co-CEO Ted Sarandos said the streamer's upcoming series 'Operation Safed Sagar' contributed 24 million dollars to the Indian economy during its production, calling the show a celebration of Netflix's 10 years in India. Speaking at the premiere of the series at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi, Sarandos said the show underscores India's filmmaking talent, technical expertise and ability to produce world-class entertainment. "It is an honour to spotlight the extraordinary courage and the service of the men and the women who served in the Kargil War. For us at 'Netflix', 'Operation Safed Sagar' is also a celebration of 10 years of 'Netflix' in India. On a cinematic scale, this series is a first for 'Netflix India'. It demonstrates the fact that India has the talent, the technical expertise, the production capability to create entertainment that stands confidently alongside the best entertainment in the world," Sarandos said. Inspired by the Indian Air Force's role during the 1999 Kar-



gil War, 'Operation Safed Sagar' follows the Golden Arrows Squadron as a group of young fighter pilots undertake high-altitude combat missions while navigating the emotional and personal costs of war. It features an ensemble cast of Siddharth, Jimmy Shergill, Dia Mirza, Abhay Verma, Prajakta Koli, Adil Hussain, Mihir Ahuja, Taaruk Raina, Arnav Bhassin and Amrita Bagchi. Sarandos said the show's production generated widespread economic activity during its 115-day shoot across 11 cities. "Our investment in this show has made a substantial 24 million dollars contribution to the Indian econ-

omy. Now, that's the result of 850 local businesses, over 200 cast and crew and 4,000 daily hires that were employed and benefited from filming during 115 days of production in 11 cities," he said. Sarandos said visual effects accounted for a significant portion of the investment. "In fact, five million dollars of those 24 million dollars was contributed alone from 'Visual Effects', a creative tech partnership. We worked with nearly 1,200 visual effects artists across 15 different studios to bring to life almost 50 minutes of breathtaking aerial sequences featured in this series," he said. PTI

'It's still a pinch-me moment'



Sharvari, currently shooting her next film alongside Ahaan Panday, recently opened up about the sustained success of 'Main Vaapas Aaunga', weeks after its release. The film continues to draw audiences, proving that organic word-of-mouth can outshine manufactured hype. Speaking to 'Hindustan Times', the actress said, "It's still a pinch-me moment. We are in our fifth week in theatres, if I'm not mistaken. That's a really long run, especially today." She admitted the film's success feels sweeter because it wasn't driven by hype but by genuine audience response. "You can never predict how deeply a film will connect. This kind of organic love and word of mouth is something you can't ask for. It has to come from the audience. I'm just really grateful

Sharvari opened up about Main Vaapas Aaunga's box office run

that the film resonated with them. There's nothing more rewarding," she added. The initial days after release were tense, as the team watched months of hard work play out at the box office. But Sharvari chose to stay hopeful. "I have always been a positive person. I genuinely believed this film would find its audience. Call it intuition or just a gut feeling, but something in my heart kept saying, 'Something good will happen,'" she said. Despite her recent successes, Sharvari said that she isn't chasing safe choices. "I love a good challenge. The dream is to live different lives through different characters and keep learning new skills. I had to prove my versatility to survive in this industry. The more varied my work is, the more directors and producers are willing to imagine me in new roles," she shared. AGENCIES

THE ODYSSEY

NOLAN'S EPIC JOURNEY AROUND THE WORLD

From Morocco's red-clay fortress to Iceland's black sands, Christopher Nolan found extraordinary settings for his latest Matt Damon film

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Christopher Nolan's epic adaptation of Homer's Greek classic 'The Odyssey' is inching towards joining the billion-dollar club. While audiences are thronging to theatres to experience what is often described as the greatest adventure story ever told, the making of the film itself has been an extraordinary journey across some of the world's most dramatic landscapes. Starring Matt Damon as Odysseus, Anne Hathaway as Penelope, Tom Holland as Telemachus and Robert Pattinson as Antinous, the film took Nolan and his massive production team to several spectacular locations across Europe and beyond. The Oscar-winning filmmaker shot the movie over 91 days, using two million feet of IMAX film. From ancient fortresses and mythical caves to windswept Scottish ruins and Iceland's stark volcanic landscapes, each location adds to the epic scale of the story.

MOROCCO

The ancient city of Troy required a setting that could convey the grandeur and devastation of one of Greek mythology's most legendary conflicts. For the fiery destruction of Troy, Nolan chose Ait Benhaddou, the spectacular red-clay fortress in Morocco. The UNESCO-listed earthen village was transformed by the production team into the besieged city of Troy. Ait Benhaddou is no stranger to epic cinema, having previously featured in major Hollywood productions including 'The Mummy' and 'Gladiator'.



Nestor's Cave in Pylos, Greece



Scotland



Italy



Ait Benhaddou, Morocco



Iceland

GREECE

SCOTLAND

For one of 'Odysseus' most frightening encounters, his confrontation with the monstrous Cyclops Polyphemus, Nolan travelled to Scotland's Moray Firth, north of the Highlands. The haunting, windswept coastline provided the backdrop for the unsettling scenes involving Circe, portrayed by Samantha Morton. Among the most disturbing moments is the sequence in which the sorceress transforms desperate soldiers into pigs. The scene was filmed in the dramatic ruins of Findlater Castle.

The world of the sorceress Circe called for something darker and more atmospheric. Nolan travelled to Scotland's Moray Firth, north of the Highlands. The haunting, windswept coastline provided the backdrop for the unsettling scenes involving Circe, portrayed by Samantha Morton. Among the most disturbing moments is the sequence in which the sorceress transforms desperate soldiers into pigs. The scene was filmed in the dramatic ruins of Findlater Castle.

ICELAND

For the film's journey into the Underworld, Nolan once again turned to the stark and otherworldly landscapes of Iceland, a country that has already featured prominently in his cinematic universe, including 'Interstellar'. The production took a crew of around 1,000 people to Hjórléifshöfði on Iceland's southern coast. With its vast black-sand landscape and primordial appearance, the location became the setting for 'Odysseus' descent into the Underworld, where he encounters the dead.

ITALY

Odysseus' ultimate destination, Ithaca, had to look rugged, beautiful and timeless. For the hero's long-awaited homeland, where his palace has been taken over by the suitors pursuing Penelope, Nolan selected Favignana, a picturesque island off the western coast of Sicily. The island's sun-drenched and rugged terrain provided the backdrop for Ithaca, while its most striking landmark, the historic Castello di Santa Caterina, became the centrepiece of the shoot.

